

The Gambia: Evaluation of the African Development Bank's Country Strategy and Program (2017–2024)

Summary Report

Country Strategy and Program Evaluations

December 2025

Acknowledgements

Task manager	Akua Arthur-Kissi, Principal Evaluation Officer, IDEV2
Task team members	Christoffer Claussen, Senior Evaluation Officer; Roland Akabzaa, Research Analyst (IDEV2)
Consultants	Charlotte Vaillant, Lead Consultant; Roberto Durero, Consultant, Transport Economist; Moustapha Corr, Consultant, Energy and Water & Sanitation; Nico Helfort, Consultant, Agriculture and Rural Development
Internal peer reviewers	Abdulkareem Lawal, Evaluation Quality Expert, Consultant, IDEV0 Girma Kumbi, Chief Evaluation Officer, IDEV2
External peer reviewer	Steven Tabor, Expert Evaluation Reviewer
Internal Bank Reference Group	Aisha Sillah, Senior National Country Economist, ECCE1; Jacob Oduor, Lead Economist-West Africa, ECCE2/RDNG; Joel Daniel Muzima, Country Economist, ECCE2; Leontine Kanziemo, Advisor; Julius Chupezi Tieguhong, Chief Forestry Officer (ECNR); Mamoru Endo, Principal Governance Officer, ECGF; Alain Pierre Mbonampeka, Lead Country Program Coordinator, RDSA; Rebecca Dadzie, Senior Agribusiness Officer, AHAI1; Bocar Cisse, Senior Financial Analyst, AHWS3/RDGW; Felix Ngmenkaara Darimaani, Principal Agro-Industrial Processing Zone Officer, AHFR.2/RDGS; O'Neil Rane, Principal Resource Mobilization & Partnerships Officer & PPF Coordinator, FIRM1/RDGE; Daniel Osei-Boakye, Procurement Officer, SNFI1/COSN; Fatimata Ball, Principal Energy Expert, PESD3/COSN; Philip Doghle, Financial Management Coordinator, SNFI2; Rudolphe Petras, Principal Results Officer, SNDR1; Muyang Achah, Senior Environmental and Social Safeguards Officer; Clement Yari, Consultant (SNSC)
External Reference Group Member	Mr. Abdoulie Jallow, Permanent Secretary, Ministry of Finance, The Gambia
Knowledge management and communication	Raky Gassama, Principal Knowledge Management Officer, Rogers Ssekubwa, Junior Consultant, and Arsene Birindwa, Communication Consultant (IDEV.3)
Other assistance/contributions	Sheila Akyea, Transport Engineer, PICU.5
Special thanks to	Bank staff and country team, for their contribution and cooperation. Development partners, representatives and external stakeholders, clients, particularly the Ministry of Finance, the Aid Coordination unit and private sector clients for their time for interviews, to arrange site visits, and to comment on evaluation findings.
Division manager	Madhusoodhanan Mampuzhasseril, IDEV2
Evaluator-General	Karen Rot-Münstermann

Table of Contents

Acknowledgements	i
Executive Summary	vi
1. INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND	13
1.1 Evaluation Purpose and Objectives.....	13
1.2 Evaluation Approach and Methodology.....	13
1.3 Limitations, Risks and Mitigation Measures	14
2. THE GAMBIA CONTEXT	15
2.1 A Changing National Context and Development Challenges	15
2.2 National Development Policies	17
3. THE BANK'S STRATEGIES AND PORTFOLIO IN THE GAMBIA.....	18
3.1 Strategic Focus	18
3.2 Portfolio Focus	19
4. FINDINGS: THE BANK'S ENGAGEMENT AND RESULTS	20
4.1 Relevance	20
4.2 Coherence	22
4.3 Effectiveness	25
4.4 Efficiency.....	34
4.5 Impact	37
4.6 Sustainability: Assuring longer-term benefits of the Bank's operations	38
5. CONCLUSIONS, LESSONS, AND RECOMMENDATIONS	39
5.1 Conclusions	39
5.2 Key Lessons	41
5.3 Recommendations	42
Annex 1: The Bank's Portfolio in The Gambia (2017–2024).....	44
Annex 2: Output and Outcome Results at CSP Level.....	46
Annex 3: Evaluation Scoring Criteria.....	54
Annex 4: Documents Consulted	57

LIST OF TABLES

Table 1: Main limitations and mitigation measures	15
Table 2: Performance achievement percentages by priority area	26
Table 3: Performance ratings by priority area	26

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1: Distribution of the Bank's assistance by instrument and sector (%), 2017–2024	19
Figure 2: Planned and actual duration (number of months) for closed projects	35
Figure 3: IPR Status of operations in The Gambia, compared with RDGW and Bank-wide performance	35

Acronyms and Abbreviations

AADT	Average Annual Daily Traffic
ADB	African Development Bank
ADF	African Development Fund
AfDB	African Development Bank Group
ADRIFi	Africa Disaster Risk Financing Program
AEFPF	African Emergency Food Production Facility
AVCDP	Agricultural Value Chains Development Project
ASYCUDA	Automated System for Customs Data
BADEA	Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa
BTOR	Back-to-Office Report
CB	Country Brief
CIF	Climate Investment Funds
CPPR	Country Portfolio Performance Review
CPIA	Country Policy and Institutional Assessment
CSP	Country Strategy Paper
CSPE	Country Strategy and Program Evaluation
CSRWASHDEP	Climate Smart Rural Water, Sanitation and Hygiene Development Project
DP	Development Partner
EIRR	Economic Internal Rate of Return
ESW	Economic and Sector Work
ESS	Environmental and Social Safeguards
EU	European Union
EUR	Euro
FASDEP	Food and Agriculture Sector Development Project
FY	Financial Year
GAFSP	Global Agriculture and Food Security Program
GAMIRSAL	Gambia Incentive-Based Risk-Sharing System for Agricultural Lending
GBA-SUDP	Greater Banjul Area—Sustainable Urban Development Program
GCF	Green Climate Fund
GDP	Gross Domestic Product
GEAP	Gambia Electricity Access Project
GEBS	Gambia Emergency Budget Support
GEF	Global Environment Facility
GESREP	Gambia Electricity System Rehabilitation and Expansion Project
GIZ	Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit
GoTG	Government of The Gambia
GWFA	Gambia Women's Finance Association
HGSF	Home-Grown School Feeding
IDEV	Independent Development Evaluation
IFAD	International Fund for Agricultural Development

IFMIS	Integrated Financial Management Information System
IGPISP	Inclusive Growth Promotion Institutional Support Project
IMF	International Monetary Fund
IOP	Indicative Operational Program
IPR	Implementation Progress Report
ISP	Institutional Support Project
ISDB	Islamic Development Bank
ITAS	Integrated Tax Administration System
M&E	Monitoring and Evaluation
MoF	Ministry of Finance
MTR	Mid-Term Review
NAWEC	National Water and Electricity Company
NDP	National Development Plan
NEA	National Environment Agency
NSS	National Seed Secretariat
ODA	Official Development Assistance
OMVG	Gambia River Basin Development Organization
OSBP	One-Stop Border Post
PAP	Project Affected Person
PAR	Project Appraisal Report
PBA	Performance-Based Allocation
PCR	Project Completion Report
PCU/PIU	Project Coordination Unit/Project Implementation Unit
PEFA	Public Expenditure and Financial Accountability
PFM	Public Financial Management
PFM-ERP	Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program
PRA	Project Results Assessment
PPP	Public-Private Partnership
PS	Permanent Secretary
PSD	Private Sector Development
RAP	Resettlement Action Plan
RDGW	Regional Development and Business Delivery Office for West Africa
REWARD	Regional West African Resilient Rice Value Chain Development Program
RF	Results Framework
RISP	Regional Integration Strategy Paper
RO	Regional Operation
RSF	Risk-Sharing Facility
RVCTP	Rice Value Chain Transformation Program
RWSSP	Rural Water Supply and Sanitation Project
SAP	Systems, Applications, and Products (in data processing)
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
SEFA	Sustainable Energy Fund for Africa

SME	Small and Medium Enterprise
SOE	State-Owned Enterprise
SPCR	Strategic Program for Climate Resilience
TAAT	Technologies for African Agricultural Transformation
ToC	Theory of Change
TSF	Transition Support Facility
UA	Unit of Account, 1 UA ≈ USD 1.35491 as of July 2025
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
URR/CRR/WCR/LRR	Upper River/Central River/West Coast/Lower River Region
USAID	United States Agency for International Development
USD	United States Dollar
VYWOSP	Vulnerable Youth and Women Support Project
WB	World Bank
WASH	Water, Sanitation and Hygiene
WFP	World Food Program

Executive Summary

Introduction and Background

This report presents the findings of an evaluation of the African Development Bank Group (AfDB or the Bank)'s country strategy and program in the Republic of The Gambia over 2017–2024 conducted by Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV). It is IDEV's first Country Strategy and Program Evaluation (CSPE) for The Gambia.

The evaluation period was defined by three strategic documents: the Country Brief ([CB 2017–2019](#)), the Country Strategy Paper ([CSP 2021–2025](#)), and the Regional Integration Strategy Paper for West Africa (RISP 2020–2025). Together, these documents aimed to address The Gambia's development challenges through targeted interventions aligned with the Bank's regional and institutional priorities.

Methodology and Limitations

The evaluation combined retrospective and prospective dimensions, assessing the performance and results of the Bank's program and drawing lessons to inform the next CSP and future strategic decisions. It evaluated program results for 2017–2024 and considered contextual developments in 2025 that may influence completion.

A theory-based approach guided the analysis. The evaluation assessed performance against a reconstructed Theory of Change (ToC) derived from the CB and CSP and applied six international evaluation criteria —relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability, and impact— using a four-point rating scale: Highly satisfactory (4), Satisfactory (3), Partly unsatisfactory (2), and Unsatisfactory (1). (See Annex 3)

Five overarching questions guided the evaluation: 1) Has the Bank made the right strategic choices? 2) Has the Bank achieved what it set out to achieve? 3) Has the Bank undertaken its interventions in the right way? 4) Which factors have facilitated or hindered the achievement of the CSPs' strategic objectives? and 5) Which lessons and recommendations can inform future Bank country strategies and programs? (See details in Technical Annex 4.)

Evidence was triangulated from multiple sources, including document reviews, stakeholder interviews, focus group discussions, a survey of Project Implementation Units (PIUs), and field visits to project sites and beneficiaries. The evaluation covered over 40 interviews, 22 survey responses, and field visits across five regions of The Gambia, complemented by a portfolio review, project performance assessments, and a thematic case study.

Key limitations included staff turnover, data gaps in project reporting, weak monitoring and evaluation (M&E) systems, and potential positive response bias. The evaluation mitigated these limitations through triangulation and extensive consultations with government counterparts, development partners, and beneficiaries.

The Bank's Strategy and Programs in The Gambia, 2017–2024

During the evaluation period, the Bank's engagement focused on supporting The Gambia's post-crisis recovery and transition. The 2017–2019 Country Brief addressed immediate post-crisis needs, while the 2021–2025 CSP emphasized modernizing agricultural value chains for inclusive growth. Both were aligned with the Bank's regional and fragility strategies and prioritized transport, energy, and agricultural infrastructure. Cross-cutting priorities included gender, climate, and capacity building.

Between 2017 and 2024, the Bank approved 34 operations totaling UA 295.22m. The portfolio was dominated by transport (31.4%) and agriculture (30.7%), followed by power (10.6%), multi-sector and finance (9.3%), and other sectors (18%). Funding sources included the African Development Fund (ADF) (61%), the Transition Support Facility (TSF) (14%), the Global Agriculture and Food Security Program Trust Fund (14%), and others (11%).

The Bank also mobilized co-financing. For three major energy projects (Gambia River Basin Development Organization - OMVG, Gambia Electricity Access Project - GEAP, and Gambia Electricity System Rehabilitation and Expansion Project - GESREP), it contributed UA 31.35m toward the total costs of UA 184.64m, achieving a leverage ratio of 5.9.

The active portfolio consisted almost entirely of sovereign operations, with only one non-sovereign operation (NSO), which was later terminated. Two NSOs initially planned under the CSP's Indicative Operational Program (IOP) did not materialize, reflecting the Bank's strategic focus on public sector-led development in a fragile context. Limited private sector capacity and high investment risks constrained NSO engagement.

Key Evaluation Findings

The findings below summarize the overall assessments under each evaluation criterion.

Relevance

The relevance of the Bank's support to The Gambia was assessed as satisfactory. The evaluation found that the Bank's assistance was well

aligned with national and sectoral priorities and consistent with the Bank's corporate objectives and thematic priorities. The program adapted to evolving national circumstances and retained its strategic focus through sustained stakeholder engagement.

However, limited resources required trade-offs, including a shift from crisis-focused Policy-Based Operations (PBOs) to resilience-oriented interventions and expanded agricultural operations, which now account for nearly one-third of the portfolio. The evaluation also identified an insufficient focus on private sector needs relative to strategic ambitions and noted gaps such as the absence of updates to the results framework, which reduced the rating.

The evaluation found that interventions were generally well targeted toward disadvantaged groups, particularly through agriculture and Water, Sanitation and Hygiene (WASH) initiatives in the poorest regions. Strategic planning and program development incorporated substantial consultation with government and development partners (DPs), although engagement with local beneficiaries and civil society could have been stronger during design and implementation.

Reforms and scaled-up interventions were found to have responded to shifting priorities, particularly in value chains and regional integration, but several major projects struggled to adapt their design and documentation to changing realities. For example, in the Trans-Gambia Corridor Project (TGCP), rushed feasibility work and reliance on outdated assessments contributed to a 30% cost increase for the bridge and the cancellation of the feeder roads component, which were critical for project relevance and impact. Interviews highlighted issues such as inadequate handover between task managers, shifting client priorities, and insufficient coordination among DPs.

Coherence

The evaluation found mixed results in coherence but assessed it as satisfactory overall. Internally, the Bank's support was generally found to be aligned with its strategic objectives. Interventions within sectors were largely coherent and mutually reinforcing, particularly where projects built on earlier efforts or addressed specific gaps. However, cross-project synergies and cross-sectoral linkages were not fully realized, limiting strategic coherence at portfolio level.

Externally, coherence was largely deemed satisfactory. Most intervention areas showed good alignment between Bank operations, other donors, and government programs, with complementarities and effective partnerships in several cases. Donor coordination mainly occurred at the project level rather than through a comprehensive program-wide

approach but still helped reduce overlap and enhance complementarity.

Despite partners' efforts to coordinate effectively, collaboration presented challenges in certain instances. In agriculture, for example, the Islamic Development Bank (IsDB) and the Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa (BADEA) were expected to cofinance the Rice Value Chain Transformation Program (RVCTP), but BADEA's contribution did not materialize. In WASH, the Climate Smart Rural Water, Sanitation and Hygiene Development Project (CSRWASHDEP) was initially approved at UA 27m, but its budget was halved when Green Climate Fund (GCF) financing did not come through.

Despite these challenges, the evaluation found that Project Coordination Units (PCUs) within sector ministries helped keep investments well-coordinated. In rural development, IsDB and BADEA focused on infrastructure, while the Bank emphasized support services. In the energy sector, the Bank, the World Bank (WB), and the European Union (EU) aligned their interventions around government programs.

Effectiveness

Due to weaknesses in the CSP performance and results measurement frameworks, including lack of updates when priorities shifted and limited monitoring and reporting, the evaluation could not assign an overall effectiveness rating. Instead, it undertook a three-part assessment: (i) a quantitative review based on CB and CSP Results Frameworks; (ii) an analysis of project-level results in infrastructure, agriculture, and governance; and (iii) an assessment of achievements in cross-cutting areas, institutional support, and knowledge work.

Firstly, assessed against the indicators in the CB/CSP Results Frameworks, performance was rated partly unsatisfactory (Annex 2). Infrastructure achieved 58.7% of targets, with stronger outcomes (70%) than outputs (41.7%). Governance and Public Financial Management (PFM) reached 54.3%, with high output delivery (85.7%) but weaker outcomes (33.3%). Agriculture and value addition achieved only 8.6% overall, reflecting persistent monitoring and reporting gaps.

Secondly, at the project level, results were found more positive (albeit mixed), with notable contributions toward CSP objectives. In **infrastructure**, the evaluation found that Bank interventions reduced travel times and transport costs, increased trade, and strengthened regional connectivity. For instance, the TGCP helped raise Annual Average Daily Traffic (AADT) from 1,027 in 2011 to a projected 4,777 by 2025, a 365% increase. Energy and WASH projects expanded access to

electricity and water and showed generally satisfactory effectiveness.

In agriculture, nine operations (UA 90.57m) contributed to modernizing key value chains, improving productivity, and expanding market linkages. The evaluation found that certified rice seed systems, improved irrigation, and new market connections under the Rice Value Chain Transformation Program (RVCTP) and the Home-Grown School Feeding Program supported food security and school attendance. The Food and Agriculture Sector Development Project (FASDEP) and Agricultural Value Chains Development Project (AVCDP) backed agro-enterprise development, mechanization, and livestock productivity, creating jobs particularly for women and youth among the targeted beneficiaries. Despite these achievements, delivery of 70% of planned outputs and 60% of expected outcomes (weighted average 64%) justified a partly unsatisfactory rating, mainly due to infrastructure delays, weak synergies, and limited engagement beyond production.

In governance, the evaluation found that interventions helped improve customs administration, public finance, and fiscal discipline, but progress on private sector development and institutional reforms was less visible. Notable results included an upgrade to the ASYCUDA World customs system, contributing to a 23% rise in customs revenue in 2023, and the adoption of a national gender policy and PFM Bill. Technical assistance, such as debt management training, strengthened implementation of the Medium-Term Debt Management Strategy and the Audit Office's capacity, but **limited progress in support for enabling private sector development constrained overall results**.

Thirdly, the evaluation found that cross-cutting issues including gender, social inclusion, climate change, and the environment were consistently reflected in project design but unevenly implemented. The current CSP sought to mainstream these priorities, yielding contributions to gender policy and climate change mitigation, although impact varied by sector and environmental and social safeguards integration remained weak.

Capacity building featured strongly across projects, with training and institutional support to entities such as the Gambia Revenue Authority, National Roads Authority, public-private partnership (PPP) Directorate, and National Audit Office. The Bank also delivered **knowledge products and technical studies** that informed sector strategies, although their use in policy dialogue was found uneven.

In terms of **factors that facilitated or hampered the achievement of results**, the evaluation found that sound project management and prudent resource

use contributed positively, while persistent weaknesses in monitoring, procurement delays, inadequate measures to sustain capacity gains, staff turnover, and regulatory gaps reduced long-term effectiveness.

Efficiency

The efficiency of the country program was found to be mixed. The evaluation assessed resource use, portfolio quality, and returns on investment as satisfactory, particularly in transport and agriculture, given The Gambia's fragile context. However, performance on timeliness, supervision, and reporting was found partly unsatisfactory.

Resource utilization was found efficient, with completed operations showing an average disbursement ratio of 95.7%. Major infrastructure projects achieved strong economic returns: 24.3% for the TGCP bridge and 67.5% for the Farafenni-Senoba road. In agriculture, consolidation of value chain activities improved resource allocation, although initial delays and procurement issues caused inefficiencies.

Most projects remained within revised budgets but faced implementation delays: 78% required extensions, and the gap between planned and actual duration ranged from one to six years. Large infrastructure initiatives such as the TGCP and OMVG Energy Project were delayed by procurement bottlenecks, staff turnover, and external shocks, including the political transition and the COVID-19 pandemic. Start-up performance was stronger than implementation: 73.5% of projects met approval-to-signature timelines, and 88% achieved first disbursement on schedule.

The evaluation found that Bank oversight and donor collaboration were adequate, but its limited in-country presence constrained supervision, partnership building, and business development. **Implementation progress reporting was found to be weak:** only 46 Implementation Progress Reports (IPRs) were produced, compared to 132 expected, which limited results tracking and learning, including for the RDGW regional portfolio. Supervision frequency and quality were also deemed low, reflecting broader challenges in monitoring and reporting.

Recurring issues were found to include inaccurate cost estimates, weak design, procurement delays, limited capacity in Project Implementation Units (PIUs), and shortages of qualified contractors. In the TGCP, outdated feasibility studies led to design revisions, a 30% cost increase (from EUR 51.7m to EUR 67.2m) and the cancellation of the feeder roads component critical for local connectivity.

Borrower performance was assessed as satisfactory overall. Project Coordination Units (PCUs) effectively managed delivery despite staffing

and capacity constraints. The creation of Central Project Coordination Units (CPCUs), especially in agriculture, improved coordination and knowledge sharing. PCU staff demonstrated competence and commitment, although engagement with civil society and external partners was limited, with most decisions centralized under the Ministry of Finance (MoF). While central coordination improved efficiency, ministries continued to face capacity and IT limitations affecting sustained performance.

Sustainability

Sustainability was assessed as partly unsatisfactory. The evaluation found that although sustainability measures were often integrated at design and sometimes effectively implemented, persistent technical, financial, institutional, and environmental gaps undermined the overall prospects for sustainable results.

Technical and financial sustainability were rated partly unsatisfactory, particularly in infrastructure. The evaluation identified ongoing concerns related to infrastructure quality, inefficiencies, high operating and maintenance costs, non-cost-reflective electricity and water tariffs, funding gaps for transport maintenance, and limited fiscal space for public investment. It acknowledged recent progress in financial sustainability through novel PPP arrangements in transport but judged risks to remain high in the absence of enacted PPP legislation. Governance support, was by contrast, more likely to be sustained, as domestic resource mobilization efforts and improvements in the investment climate were expected to help reduce public debt over time.

Institutional sustainability was found to be a significant concern. The National Water and Electricity Company of The Gambia (NAWEC) continued to face inefficiencies, capacity gaps, and an inability to achieve cost-reflective tariffs. High staff turnover in key governance institutions and continued dependence on external financing for public investments further constrained long-term sustainability.

Social sustainability was deemed satisfactory, largely because gender considerations were systematically mainstreamed and, to some extent, social inclusion was addressed in project design and implementation. **Environmental sustainability, however, was rated partly unsatisfactory.** The evaluation identified implementation challenges, limited monitoring of environmental outcomes, and growing climate and population pressures, all of which weakened the durability of environmental benefits.

Impact

The evaluation assessed the impact of the Bank's support to The Gambia as satisfactory overall, despite some notable shortcomings. The

TGCP emerged as a transformative investment that significantly enhanced regional connectivity, trade, and economic opportunities. At the same time, the evaluation found that full local benefits had not yet been realized, due to incomplete feeder roads, underutilized market infrastructure, delays caused by increased checkpoints, and stakeholder tensions. These issues highlighted the need for stronger coordination and more adaptive management to fully capture the project's potential impact.

Across sectors, Bank-funded projects in water, sanitation, energy, and agriculture generated tangible benefits for targeted communities. The evaluation found that these interventions improved access to essential services, supported income generation, and strengthened food security, particularly for women and vulnerable groups. Water and sanitation projects reduced time spent collecting water and created new livelihood opportunities, while energy and agricultural initiatives contributed to higher productivity and better access to social infrastructure.

However, the evaluation also found that persistent macroeconomic and governance challenges limited broader transformational impact. Operational constraints, including partial implementation of some projects and procedural delays, reduced the full realization of expected benefits. These findings underscored the need for continued reforms, more realistic project design, and stronger monitoring, supervision, and oversight to maximize future impact and support sustainable development in The Gambia.

Conclusions

The Bank's support to The Gambia (2017–2024) delivered meaningful but uneven results. The Bank responded flexibly to major shocks, including the political transition and the COVID-19 pandemic, but limited national capacity, resource constraints, and implementation delays reduced the scale and depth of program impacts.

The Bank's support was broadly aligned with national priorities and its adaptive approach fostered continued relevance, contributing to important results in infrastructure, governance, and regional connectivity. Investments such as the Senegambia Bridge and improved access to electricity and water supported economic activity and service delivery. However, design weaknesses, gaps in monitoring and results measurement, and limited progress on private sector development and poverty reduction constrained achievement of higher-level objectives.

Coherence, efficiency, and effectiveness were assessed as mixed. Coherence was found satisfactory overall, but the evaluation identified missed opportunities to create stronger synergies

across projects and sectors. Resource use and operational efficiency were generally deemed satisfactory, but challenges remain in project integration, donor coordination, timeliness of implementation, program management, monitoring and reporting, and long-term sustainability. While Bank operations generated positive impacts for targeted communities, broader social outcomes fell short of expectations, and some interventions experienced unintended negative effects.

Cross-cutting themes such as gender, social inclusion, capacity building, climate change and environmental and social safeguards (ESS) received attention, particularly at design stage, but their integration and follow-through were uneven. The Bank was viewed as a trusted partner in policy dialogue, although its limited in-country presence reduced its ability to fully leverage partnerships, business development, and implementation support.

In summary, the Bank's engagement helped lay foundations for longer-term development, particularly through infrastructure, resilience and food sufficiency support, and governance reforms. However, most results remained concentrated at the level of direct beneficiaries rather than driving wider transformational change. Unlocking this potential will require stronger project and program monitoring, more robust sustainability measures, and deeper collaboration with national stakeholders and development partners to enhance impact and support The Gambia's development agenda.

Lessons

The evaluation identified the following key lessons:

- **Maintaining strategic focus for results and impact requires balancing consistency and flexibility in the context of competing demands and limited resources.** The Bank's experience demonstrates the importance of maintaining a realistic, well-prioritized and clear strategic direction, while remaining adaptable to changing national priorities and external shocks, such as political transitions and the COVID-19 pandemic, in a context of limited resources and increasing demands. For example, while the CSP emphasized agricultural value chains, implementation included some unrelated projects, which contributed to fragmentation and missed opportunities for cross-sectoral integration and synergies. Future strategies should maintain a clear strategic direction, grounded in areas of comparative advantage, and be regularly updated to remain responsive and realistic. A focused approach, supported by co-financing and strong government engagement, will help ensure that resources are
- targeted and aligned, thereby maximizing developmental outcomes.
- **Government capacity and ownership are essential for enhanced performance.** Experience from the Bank's operations in The Gambia highlighted that project outcomes improve significantly when Project Coordination Units have strong capacity and when government ownership is genuine and sustained. The Bank's experience shows that, while improvements were made, especially in project performance, sustained government engagement and continued capacity-building, particularly in project management and the application of environmental and social safeguards, remain essential for optimal results.
- **Effective private sector engagement requires contextual understanding and robust frameworks.** The Bank's experience in The Gambia shows that successful private sector engagement, including PPPs and support to small and medium enterprises (SMEs), depends on a sound understanding of the local context and clear legal and institutional frameworks. In The Gambia, unclear regulations and limited institutional capacity contributed to delays and missed opportunities. Better results were achieved where regulatory requirements were clear and institutional support was strong, enabling innovation and more effective risk management.
- **Sustainability requires more than community involvement and training activities.** The Bank's experience underscores that while prioritizing community ownership and investing in capacity building enhanced the likelihood of project sustainability, these factors alone were not sufficient to guarantee long-term success. Ongoing challenges in funding and institutional support, along with leadership turnover, limited lasting impact. Effective sustainability requires secure financing, strong institutions, and clear post-project responsibilities in addition to community involvement and training
- **Effective and comprehensive strong M&E systems are crucial for accountability, results tracking and improved project and program delivery.** A key lesson is that a clear, externally validated M&E system is essential for accountability and accurate results tracking. Projects lacking well-defined indicators and consistent reporting tools struggled with performance monitoring, transparency, and timely corrective action. The evaluation's own experience in assessing program effectiveness further highlighted that changes in program activities need to be accompanied by

corresponding revisions to results frameworks to ensure accurate performance and results reporting.

Recommendations

Based on the evaluation's findings, IDEV makes the following recommendations to the Bank:

1. Building on previous achievements in infrastructure development, prioritize comprehensive, program-based strategies to advance progress and achieve nationwide impact.

The evaluation found that Bank infrastructure initiatives delivered notable results, contributing to regional connectivity and cross border trade, food security, and rural income enhancement. Interventions effectively addressed the needs of vulnerable groups, and flexibly targeted priority areas using diverse funding sources to complement the Bank's limited resource envelope. However, the benefits were found to be limited to the directly targeted populations, and programs could not achieve their desired country-level impact due to their individual approach and modest scale.

Actions to consider include:

- 1.1. Supporting investments and institutional reforms which have country-wide transformational impact, such as the development of economic corridors integrating rural and regional road networks, market access, rural electrification, environment and climate mitigation, and agro-industrial development.
 - 1.2. Adopting a program-based approach to target key resources and partnerships for larger, integrated and higher-impact operations.
 - 1.3. Continuing to enhance resource mobilization efforts through co-financing, innovative funding sources, PPPs and the regional operations envelope, while managing risks surrounding innovative funding and PPPs by ensuring that there is an adequate legal framework underpinning these efforts.
- ### **2. Enhance Governance and Public Financial Management support to address capacity weaknesses and improve performance of key public sector institutions.**

Governance and PFM remain as key development challenges, despite significant capacity building and technical assistance contributions from the Bank and other partners. Key outcome indicators remain low, with persistent issues in institutional capacity, budget credibility, debt sustainability, and SOE performance. It is recommended that the Bank build on past efforts and continue to collaborate with

partners, and to consider prioritizing the following actions:

- 2.1. Continuing to support efforts to improve public debt management and PFM, particularly those aimed at addressing weaknesses in institutional capacity.
- 2.2. Actively pursuing interventions that complement and synergize with other Bank development efforts and other development partners' capacity building and technical assistance activities.
3. **Expand support for private sector development to accelerate the country's economic transformation, while aligning with the Bank's ongoing focus on enhancing PSD under its regional strategy.**

The evaluation found that progress in private sector development was limited, as the planned activities to improve the business climate and to support institutional capacity development were not fully achieved, despite the sector's continued importance for The Gambia's development priorities. Private sector development is considered a pillar for economic transformation, and the Bank may consider the following to expand its support:

- 3.1. Enhancing engagement in upstream activities, such as embedding policy dialogue and reform support within broader infrastructure and other sector interventions to ensure private sector benefits such as market friendly environment and enhanced access to finance are realized.
4. **Strengthen dialogue with the Government of The Gambia and Project Implementation Units to address operational and implementation challenges, while considerably improving the Bank's project supervision, results monitoring, and reporting.**

The evaluation identified key factors affecting implementation and overall program performance, including weak monitoring and reporting, inadequate design quality, institutional capacity constraints in some sectors, procurement delays, frequent staff turnover and poor handover in both the Bank and government agencies, and external disruptions like the COVID-19 pandemic. Insufficient engagement due to resource constraints and limited physical country presence has limited the desired partnership and coordination with the Government, development partners, and key stakeholders.

Suggested actions may consist of:

- 4.1. Establishing a strong results-based M&E system to meet the Bank's information needs for program oversight, results monitoring and

reporting, and strategic decision-making over the entire program cycle.

- 4.2. Ensuring that the designs of new operations are underpinned by solid feasibility studies, with clear consideration of the country context including institutional capacity.
- 4.3. Enhancing dialogue with the Government and coordination and harmonization of assistance with development partners through enhanced engagement, with adequate resources and country presence to support program planning, design, development and implementation

1. INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND

This report presents the findings of the African Development Bank Group (AfDB or “the Bank”)’s country strategy and program in the Republic of The Gambia over 2017–2024 conducted by Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV). It is IDEV’s first Country Strategy and Program Evaluation (CSPE) for The Gambia. The evaluation period was guided by three key strategy documents: the Country Brief (CB 2017–2019), the Country Strategy Paper (CSP 2021–2025), and the Regional Integration Strategy Paper for West Africa (RISP 2020–2025), which sought to address The Gambia’s development challenges.

This summary report is based on the intermediary working papers produced for the evaluation, including a portfolio review, a case study of the Trans-Gambia Corridor Project (TGCP), and a detailed technical report. It provides an overview of the country context (Section 2) and of the Bank’s CSP and program in The Gambia over the period under review (Section 3). Section 4 presents the main findings and ratings for each evaluation criterion (relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, impact, and sustainability). Section 5 sets out the conclusions, lessons, and recommendations.

This evaluation forms part of Independent Development Evaluation (IDEV)’s work plan approved by the Bank’s Board of Directors. It is timely because it (i) constitutes the first independent evaluation of the Bank’s interventions in The Gambia; (ii) generates lessons to inform the preparation of a new Gambia CSP as of 2026; and (iii) provides recommendations to the Bank that build on the strengths of the current country and regional strategies.

1.1 Evaluation Purpose and Objectives

The evaluation had both retrospective and prospective dimensions. Its main purposes were to (i) strengthen accountability for the Bank’s interventions in The Gambia, and (ii) promote learning to inform future performance improvements. It assessed the results and management of the Bank’s engagement over the period, identified drivers of program performance, and provided key lessons and recommendations to guide future interventions, including the development of the next CSP for 2026–2030. It also considered key country factors in 2025 that may influence results and program completion by the last quarter of 2025.

The evaluation period 2017–2024 covered 34 projects with a total value of UA 295.22m. It assessed the Bank’s engagement in The Gambia across lending and non-lending interventions, in the context of notable events during the period, including the political transition in 2017 and the COVID-19 pandemic in 2020. The scope included all closed/completed, ongoing and approved interventions, as well as non-lending activities such as policy dialogue and engagement with other Development Partners (DPs).

The scope was further refined to reflect salient issues identified during the inception mission to the country in February–March 2025.¹ These issues informed the formulation of the Evaluation Questions (EQs) and received particular emphasis in the main findings, conclusions, lessons, and recommendations of this report.

1.2 Evaluation Approach and Methodology

The evaluation adopted a theory-based approach that defined the links between activities and intended objectives, and then examined performance evidence against what had been anticipated at program design (see Technical Annex 3 for details). It applied the four-point rating scale set out in IDEV’s evaluation manual—Highly satisfactory (4), Satisfactory (3), Partly unsatisfactory (2), and Unsatisfactory (1)—to the criteria of relevance, coherence, effectiveness, efficiency, sustainability, and

¹ The evaluation mission joined the CSP completion mission consultations scheduled during the same period to avoid duplication of efforts.

impact (see Annex 3 for details). The evaluation also carefully considered contextual risks and assumptions, particularly when assessing effectiveness and efficiency.

The evaluation methodology followed an in-depth assessment of key sectors that formed the backbone of the main pillars of the assistance strategies, focusing on completed operations (results and achievements) and overall operations (program development and management performance) in three areas: (i) Infrastructure development (transport, energy, water supply and sanitation [WASH]); (ii) Governance and Public Financial Management (PFM); and (iii) Agriculture and rural development, including environment.

The evaluation combined three levels of analysis (“units of study”): strategic and portfolio analysis; pillar-level/strategic focus analysis; and project-level analysis. The portfolio analysis assessed trends over the study period, for example in timeliness and efficiency. It also compared portfolio performance data for selected indicators with regional targets, to benchmark the performance of The Gambia portfolio against Bank-wide and regional performance.

For data collection and analysis, the evaluation adopted a mixed-methods approach, combining quantitative and qualitative methods and enabling triangulation across primary and secondary data sources. Primary data sources included key informant interviews, a perception survey of Project Implementation Units (PIUs) and government coordination staff and focus group discussions with beneficiaries and other targeted stakeholders. Secondary data came from desk research and document reviews.

The evaluation also conducted an in-depth case study of transport and regional integration focused on the TGCP, including the Senegambia Bridge. Almost half of the Bank’s support during the period under review went to the transport sector, mainly through the regional integration financing envelope. The TGCP was selected for detailed review because of its size, longevity, and regional dimension, making it the Bank’s flagship program in The Gambia portfolio during the period. The case study was used extensively to inform the assessment of the impact of the Bank’s support.

By examining performance through these different levels of analysis, the evaluation drew on multiple sources of information, including national and program data, interviews, field verification, and triangulation across sources. It sought to answer five broad EQs, structured around the main evaluation criteria:

1. Has the Bank made the right strategic choices? (relevance)
2. Has the Bank achieved what it set out to achieve? (effectiveness)
3. Has the Bank undertaken its interventions in the right way? (coherence and efficiency)
4. Which factors have affected performance (effectiveness and program management)? and
5. Which lessons and recommendations can inform future Bank assistance strategies and programs?

An evaluation matrix (Technical Annex 4) was developed, setting out key issues, evaluation criteria, EQs, indicators, judgment criteria, and sources of information. Sufficient information was gathered to draw evidence-based evaluative judgments, despite challenges such as limited data availability and weak monitoring and reporting, particularly for cross-cutting indicators. Consequently, the evaluation focused on how cross-cutting dimensions were addressed and included selected cross-cutting outputs, without assigning performance ratings for the delivering of cross-cutting results. Interview data were triangulated with other evidence, including survey responses, to enhance validity.

1.3 Limitations, Risks and Mitigation Measures

The main limitations encountered during this evaluation related to the strength and completeness of the evidence base. Table 1 summarizes these limitations and the corresponding mitigation measures.

Table 1: Main limitations and mitigation measures

Main limitations	Mitigation measures
Staff turnover over the period under review	The evaluation team included former Task Managers (TMs) in the interview schedule. In some cases, it was not possible to interview former TMs because they had left the Bank. Despite staff turnover, institutional memory for most projects was relatively strong on the Gambian side, with many key stakeholders involved from the beginning of the projects.
Poor Quality and Availability of Bank Project Documents and Self-reporting	Implementation Progress Reports (IPRs) and Project Completion Reports (PCRs), as self-reporting tools, and the indicators in their performance frameworks, were often found to lack up-to-date and verifiable evidence. To compensate for this limitation, the evaluation team collected and reviewed as many supervision Back-to-Office Reports (BTORs) and aide-memoires as possible (although some could not be located ²), as well as quarterly progress reports from the implementing agency for transport. In addition, the evaluation used stakeholder perceptions and, importantly, field visits as primary sources, allowing direct observation and feedback from final beneficiaries.
Possible response bias for the PCU survey.	Feedback on Project Coordination Unit (PCU) capacity and performance was generally positive in the survey responses, indicating a risk of positive response bias. To ensure robustness, the evaluation team triangulated survey data with other sources, including individual interviews with Bank TMs, PCUs, and other relevant stakeholders, as well as information available from IPRs, PCRs, and supervision BTORs.
Data quality and availability issues due to weak M&E capacities and problematic results frameworks	The country's access to comprehensive, robust, up-to-date, and disaggregated country- and sector-level data was limited. This was compounded by limited attention from the Bank to establishing an effective and functioning results measurement framework for the program. The evaluation team carried out extensive field visits and beneficiary interviews to capture primary data and obtain direct observations. This was complemented by an extensive review of external documents and interviews with former Bank staff to support a comprehensive assessment. The evaluation addressed the constraints to assigning a definitive rating for program effectiveness arising from the lack of updates to performance indicators in the Results Frameworks, which showed mismatches between CSP-focused indicators and intervention-level indicators. To present a fair and balanced picture of program performance, the evaluation adopted a multi-tiered approach: (i) a quantitative assessment of results against the Results Frameworks "as is" and (ii) an assessment of the contribution of project-level results to the priority areas of the program under the two strategy periods.

2. THE GAMBIA CONTEXT

2.1 A Changing National Context and Development Challenges

The Gambia has made significant progress in political stability and institutional reform since the 2016 transition of power. The country has improved its democratic processes, including holding free and fair elections, and has strengthened its commitment to human rights. However, challenges remain in areas such as public sector reform and anti-corruption efforts. The Gambia has embarked on a comprehensive public sector reform program, supported by several DPs including the AfDB, aimed at strengthening public policy and institutions and improving public sector performance.

In 2024, The Gambia's gross domestic product (GDP) was estimated at USD 2.69bn, with GDP per capita at USD 908.5.³ The economy remained broadly stable after the COVID-19 shock in 2020. Real GDP growth averaged 5.3% between 2021 and 2024, above the averages for West Africa (4.1%) and

² BTOR/AM were made available in energy, WASH, and governance, but only a few for transport and none in agriculture.

³ AfDB, 2025. The Gambia Country Strategy Paper 2021–2025 Completion Report and 2024 Country Portfolio Performance Report 2024. DARMS ref. ADB/BD/WP/2025/122 & ADF/BD/WP/2025/71.

Africa (3.8%) over the same period. However, growth remained below pre-COVID-19 levels of 7.2% in 2017 and 6.2% in 2019, indicating that the country was still in a recovery phase.

The economy is driven mainly by agriculture, tourism, and remittances. Agriculture contributes 20.6% of GDP and is an income source for about 70% of the population. The sector is dominated by small-scale subsistence production of groundnuts, coarse grains, rice, and cassava. Tourism accounts for more than 20% of GDP and is a growing source of employment and foreign exchange. The Gambia also has a significant proportion of its population (about one tenth) living abroad, and remittances account for more than 20% of GDP.⁴

Inflation reached double-digit levels in recent years, rising from 5.9% in 2020 to 16.6% in 2023 (AfDB, 2024),⁵ before moderating to 14.4% in 2024. The Central Bank of The Gambia maintained its policy rate at 17%, unchanged since August 2023.⁶ However, the inflation outlook remained more favorable than in the wider West African region. The current account deficit was projected to fall to 4.5% of GDP in 2024, down from 8.9% in 2023, largely due to increased tourism, higher remittances, and lower investment-related imports (see Technical Annex 1). Under the International Monetary Fund (IMF) program, Government efforts to boost revenue mobilization increased the revenue-to-GDP ratio from 16.8% in 2021 to 18.7% in 2023, and reduced the fiscal deficit from 4.9% of GDP in 2021 to 3.5% in 2024. Public debt declined from 84.9% of GDP in 2020 to 73.5% in 2024. However, rising debt service costs, which increased from 7.3% to 19.4% of GDP over the same period, pose significant fiscal risks. A 2024 World Bank/IMF analysis flagged debt vulnerabilities and a high risk of debt distress, although overall debt levels remained sustainable.

Poverty levels in The Gambia have remained persistently high. In 2020, 53.4% of the population was classified as poor, according to national poverty rates. Against the international poverty line of USD 2.15,⁷ extreme poverty rose to 20.3% in 2022. As of 2024, an estimated 29% of the population (2.4 million people) was food insecure, and 24% of households had inadequate food consumption.⁸ The Gambia's Gini coefficient averaged 38.7 over 2020–2025,⁹ indicating moderate income inequality. Growth remained insufficiently inclusive, with wide social disparities between rural and urban areas. Overall unemployment remained high, at about 58.5% over the last three years.¹⁰ The country is highly susceptible to climate change, including droughts and floods, which continue to undermine poverty reduction and resilience efforts.

The Gambia's main development partners, in addition to the Bank, include the World Bank (WB), the IMF, the European Union (EU), the Islamic Development Bank (IsDB), the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), France, and, until recently, the United States of America (USA). The Gambia also receives assistance from Arab states and regional organizations, including the Arab Fund for Economic and Social Development. Over time, reliance has shifted from domestic debt to multilateral and bilateral debt. Multilateral and bilateral debt increased from 57.6% and 17.2% of total debt in 2020 to 64% and 20.2% in 2024, respectively. The proportion of domestic debt declined from 42.4% of total debt in 2020 to 36% in 2024.¹¹

2.1.1 Governance

Governance reforms since 2016, supported by several development partners including the Bank, have contributed to progress in transparency, participation, and accountability. This has been reflected in stronger scores in the Ibrahim Index of African Governance (IIAG) (ranked 20th out of 54 countries in

⁴ AfDB (2023b). Project Appraisal Report: Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program (PFM-ERP)—Phase I.

⁵ AfDB (2024). African Economic Outlook: Country Focus Report—The Gambia (<https://www.afdb.org/en/documents/country-focus-report-2024-gambia-driving-gambias-transformation-reform-global-financial-architecture>)

⁶ Central Bank of The Gambia, 2025. *Monetary Policy Committee Press Release 27 February 2025*. <https://www.cbq.gm/Monetary%20Policy%20Committee>

⁷ In June 2025, the World Bank updated the International Poverty Line to USD 3.00 per person per day, replacing the previous USD 2.15 threshold, based on the latest 2021 Purchasing Power Parity data.

⁸ WFP (2025). The Gambia, Home-Grown School Meals Programme: Impact Evaluation. Rome

⁹ World Bank (2025). DataBank: World Development Indicators, <https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>

¹⁰ AfDB (2024b). African Economic Outlook: Country Focus Report—The Gambia (<https://www.afdb.org/en/documents/country-focus-report-2024-gambia-driving-gambias-transformation-reform-global-financial-architecture>)

¹¹ IMF (2024), Macroeconomic and Distributional Implications of Gender Gaps — The Gambia

2024), Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI) (ranked 98th out of 180 countries, with a score of 37 out of 100¹²), and the World Bank's Country Policy and Institutional Assessment (CPIA), which improved from 2.97 in 2016 to 3.1 in 2022.¹³

Despite this progress, significant challenges remain. PFM, the rule of law, and anti-corruption institutions continue to face capacity gaps. Public-private partnerships (PPPs) are increasingly used to bridge infrastructure gaps; however, a PPP law is still pending enactment.¹⁴

2.1.2 Development challenges

The Gambia continues to face several long-standing development challenges, including:

- **Fragility:** The Gambia remains classified as a transition state, with a Fragility Index of 76.1 out of 120 (unchanged from 2023).¹⁵ Key risks include political exclusion, inequality, climate hazards, and poverty.
- **Unemployment:** Overall unemployment is estimated at around 50%, with youth unemployment reaching nearly 11% in 2024.¹⁶
- **Macroeconomic constraints:** High public debt (see above), and dependence on remittances, tourism, and external aid constrain fiscal space and increase vulnerability to external shocks.¹⁷
- **Governance capacity:** Despite progress, PFM remains weak; the 2022 Public Expenditure and Financial Accountability (PEFA) assessment rated most categories poorly. Institutional capacity is undermined by staff turnover, limited resources, and weak coordination.
- **Food security:** Nearly 30% of the population is food insecure. Agriculture remains largely subsistence-based, vulnerable to climate change, and poorly mechanized.
- **Infrastructure:** Persistent gaps in transport, energy, water, sanitation, and information and communication technology (ICT) constrain development and private investment.
- **Private sector:** The private sector remains narrow and largely informal, with limited access to credit (8.7% of GDP), high operating costs, weak regulation, and low skills.
- **Security:** Regional instability and irregular migration continue to pose risks.
- **Climate:** The Gambia is highly vulnerable to climate change, a situation exacerbated by population pressures and resource degradation.

2.2 National Development Policies

Since 2017, The Gambia has focused on restoring governance, economic resilience, and inclusive growth. The short-term Accelerated National Response Plan¹⁸ (ANRP, 2017) paved the way for the National Development Plan (NDP 2018–2022), which emphasized democratic governance, private sector—driven job creation and improved social services.

The current Recovery-Focused NDP (2023–2027) prioritizes consolidating democratic gains, accelerating green economic and social transformation, and strengthening resilience to shocks, with

¹² Corruption Perception Index (2024): showing an increase of 3 points since 2022—
<https://www.transparency.org/en/countries/gambia>

¹³ The latest confirmed AfDB's CPIA for The Gambia has shown marginally improvement from 2.97 in 2016 to 3.1 in 2022. The World Bank's CPIA increased marginally from 2.9 in 2016 to 3.1 in 2024.

¹⁴ The Gambia has made progress by implementing a PPP Policy and corresponding operational guidelines, though the country has not yet enacted its recently drafted PPP Bill supported by international partners

¹⁵ (FFP 2023). Fragile State Index Annual Report 2023. https://fragilestatesindex.org/wp-content/uploads/2023/06/FSI-2023-Report_final.pdf

¹⁶ World Bank-IMF (2025). *The Gambia—Joint World Bank-IMF Debt Sustainability Analysis* Washington, D.C.: World Bank

¹⁷ World Bank (2025). DataBank: World Development Indicators, <https://databank.worldbank.org/source/world-development-indicators>, and AfDB (2024b). African Economic Outlook: Country Focus Report—The Gambia (<https://www.afdb.org/en/documents/country-focus-report-2024-gambia-driving-gambias-transformation-reform-global-financial-architecture>)

¹⁸ In the immediate aftermath of the political transition, the government adopted the Accelerated National Response Plan (ANRP) for the period July—December 2017, which served as a short-term recovery strategy to stabilize the country and guide early reforms.

strategic pillars in governance, macroeconomic stability, human capital, agriculture, infrastructure, and digital connectivity.¹⁹ It envisages economic transformation through private sector-driven job creation and improved social services, and sets out development policies framed by the Sustainable Development Strategy (SDS) 2030 agenda. The Bank's last three strategy documents have been aligned with the key principles of the NDP and the SDS targets, in order to address persistent challenges including poverty, hunger, inequality, and environmental degradation.

3. THE BANK'S STRATEGIES AND PORTFOLIO IN THE GAMBIA

3.1 Strategic Focus

The Gambia is classified as an African Development Fund (ADF)-only country, eligible for the Transition Support Facility (TSF) and various trust funds. It receives only grants and concessional loans, as it is considered at high risk of debt distress.

The Bank's Country Brief (CB) and CSP for The Gambia have mainly focused on agriculture and infrastructure development, with the long-term objective of laying the foundations for socioeconomic transformation. Both strategies are closely aligned with the RISP 2020–2025, which emphasizes regional integration, economic diversification, and structural transformation in West Africa.

In addition, a short-term stabilization objective remained relevant for much of the evaluation period, particularly during the COVID-19 pandemic. The Bank's program evolved under these three strategic frameworks, while maintaining continuity across the main areas of intervention.

3.1.1 Bank's Strategic Engagement in The Gambia

Over the review period, the Bank implemented two distinct country strategies in The Gambia: the CB, which supported the country's transition following the 2016 crisis, and the CSP, which adopted a focused single-pillar approach. Throughout this period, the Bank sought to balance strategic consistency with adaptability to changing country circumstances.

Country Brief (2017–2019). The CB provided a framework to deliver targeted assistance during a critical transitional phase. It aimed to stabilize the economy, restore confidence, and address governance and economic management challenges. Guided by the ANRP, the CB initially comprised five interventions, later expanded to nine, with total funding of UA 30m from the ADF, supplemented by TSF resources and contributions from other partners.

Country Strategy Paper (2021–2025). Following a favorable portfolio performance assessment 2020, the Bank prepared its first full post-crisis CSP, designed to support economic recovery from the COVID-19 shock and election-related uncertainties. The CSP is structured around a single core pillar: modernization of agricultural value chains for inclusive growth, with emphasis on transforming production and processing to strengthen food security. The original CSP program included seven lending operations valued at UA 87.11m, to be financed through the ADF, TSF Pillar 1, private sector funds, and the Global Agriculture and Food Security Program (GAFSP). The Mid-Term Review in June 2024 revised this pipeline to eight lending operations valued at UA 80.14m.

Regional Integration Strategy Paper for West Africa (2020–2025). Regional integration remained a key priority over the period. The CSP is aligned with West Africa RISP 2020–2025, which prioritizes investment in transport, energy, and agricultural infrastructure to reinforce regional value chains. This approach is also consistent with the Bank's Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa (2022–2026).

Across these strategic frameworks, Bank interventions generally built on previous progress. In agriculture, support focused on improving food security, raising productivity, and strengthening value chains. In energy, the emphasis was on expanding access to cleaner and more reliable energy. In transport, the Bank supported major infrastructure such as the Banjul Port expansion and the

¹⁹ AfDB (2024a). The Gambia—Country Strategy Paper 2021–2025 Mid-Term Review (CSP–MTR) and 2024 Country Portfolio Performance Review (CPPR)

Senegambia Bridge under the TGCP. More recent initiatives included the Gambia Incentive-Based Risk-Sharing System for Agricultural Lending (GAMIRSAL), social protection measures such as the PFM-ERP, and the Vulnerable Youth and Women Support Project (VYWOSP), which together signal a stronger focus on social inclusion and protection.

The CSP 2021–2025’s exclusive focus on modernizing agricultural value chains for inclusive growth heightened attention to cross-sectoral linkages across the portfolio. The CSP seeks to integrate agricultural value chains with tourism and export markets, while treating governance as a cross-cutting concern, particularly in relation to domestic resource mobilization, sector policy enhancement, and business climate reforms.

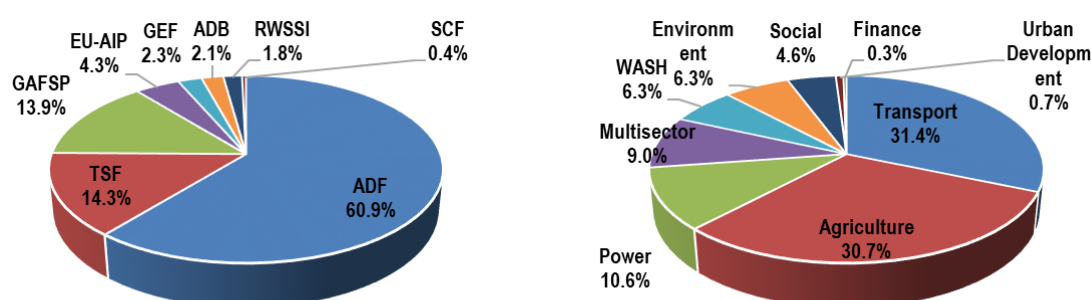
Gender and social inclusion, climate change and environmental management, and capacity building (including support for the private sector) were addressed as cross-cutting issues during the period under review. The selection and emphasis of these priorities varied across the three key strategic documents: the CB emphasized gender mainstreaming, nutrition, hygiene, and access to water and sanitation; the CSP 2021–2025 prioritized gender, governance, climate change, and fragility; and the RISP 2020–2025 identified capacity building, gender, fragility, climate change and environment, and youth unemployment as key cross-sectoral challenges.

3.2 Portfolio Focus

The Bank’s portfolio in The Gambia over 2017–2024 comprised 34 projects with a total value of UA 295.22m (see Annex 1). The portfolio was concentrated in: Transport (31.4% or UA 92.65m); Agriculture and rural development (30.7% or UA 90.57m); Power (10.6% or UA 31.35m); Multi-sector (9.3% or UA 26.67m); Water supply and sanitation (6.3% or UA 18.64m); Environment (6.3% or UA 18.63m); and Social sectors (4.6% or UA 13.68m). Urban development and finance together accounted for about 1% (approximately UA 3m) of the portfolio. This pattern reflects the Bank’s continued emphasis on infrastructure and on agriculture and rural development.

Out of the 34 projects, six projects worth UA 108.01m (37%) were approved before the evaluation period (that is, before 2017), and 28 projects valued at UA 187.21m were approved between 2017 and 2024. The portfolio consisted predominantly of grants (94%), with only 6% in loans. This structure reflects significant resource mobilization from multiple sources to compensate for the small ADF allocation for The Gambia. The main source of financing was the ADF envelope, which contributed about 61% of total commitments. This was followed by the TSF (14%) and the GAFSP Trust Fund (14%). The remaining resources came from the European Union’s Africa Investment Platform (EU-AIP), the Global Environment Facility (GEF), the African Development Bank (ADB) sovereign window, the Rural Water Supply & Sanitation Initiative Fund (RWSSI Fund), and the Strategic Climate Fund (SCF)—see Figure 1.

Figure 1: Distribution of the Bank’s assistance by instrument and sector (%), 2017–2024



Source: Compiled by the evaluation team based on SAP data extracted as of April 30, 2025

The Bank’s portfolio in The Gambia was characterized by relatively small project sizes, with an overall average of UA 8.8m. The TGCP, approved before the evaluation period (in 2011) for UA 63.55m, was the largest operation. The prevalence of smaller projects initially reflected a deliberate strategy to

mobilize resources from diverse sources, including trust funds and co-financing, in order to respond to extensive and varied development needs within a constrained ADF/ADB allocation. In recent years, however, there has been a strategic shift toward larger and more transformative operations. Average project size increased to about UA 12m in 2022–2024, above the portfolio-wide average of UA 8.8m. This shift is evident in approvals ranging from UA 0.93m (2017) to UA 30m (2024) in agriculture, and aligns with the Bank's selectivity approach.

In agriculture, the strategy moved from numerous small, stand-alone projects to integrated, value chain-wide interventions such as the Regional West African Resilient Rice Value Chain Development Program (REWARD) Project. Project design increasingly emphasized cross-sectoral linkages, and there has been a growing focus on social interventions, illustrated by the approval of the VYWOSP in 2023. In governance, the approach evolved from crisis-response operations to supporting longer-term resilience. Recent interventions focused on domestic resource mobilization, social inclusion, climate adaptation, and private sector financing, including operations such as GAMIRSAL and the Inclusive Growth Promotion Institutional Support Project (IGPISP).

An analysis of the Indicative Operational Program (IOP) for 2017–2024 showed that more projects were ultimately approved and implemented than originally planned, largely due to successful resource mobilization from trust funds and the ADF regional envelope. This expansion enabled the Bank to exceed original targets under both the CB 2017–2019 (nine projects achieved versus four planned)²⁰ and the CSP 2021–2025 (11 projects achieved versus seven planned), although two planned projects had not been implemented as of December 2024 due to shifts in government priorities. Non-lending activities, including economic and sector work and program studies, also played an important role in informing policy dialogue and project design, although their influence varied across sectors and over time.

4. FINDINGS: THE BANK'S ENGAGEMENT AND RESULTS

4.1 Relevance

The relevance criterion assessed the extent to which the Bank's country strategy and interventions responded to the evolving needs, priorities, and policies of The Gambia, its institutions, and beneficiaries. It considered both the strategic alignment with national and sectoral frameworks and the responsiveness of program design to changing circumstances. The evaluation also examined the quality of intervention design.

The evaluation found the relevance of the Bank's program to be satisfactory, reflecting strong alignment with national priorities, sector priorities, and the Bank's high-level strategic objectives. However, the evaluation also identified limitations in design quality, target clarity, and coordination with development partners, particularly for the key infrastructure project, which tempered the overall assessment.

4.1.1 Alignment and Responsiveness

The evaluation found that the Bank's broad engagement with stakeholders helped inform CSP's strategic and operational directions. **The program was largely adapted to the evolving country context by incorporating new priorities and responding to requests from national stakeholders. However, the evaluation found that these changes were not systematically formalized or reflected in the CB/CSP results frameworks,** leading to discrepancies between planned activities and results, and activities on the ground. The evaluation also found issues related to missing baselines or targets for performance indicators, particularly in relation to the CB (see Annex 2-G).

A review of the country's main development and sector strategies by the evaluation team confirmed a strong alignment of the CB and CSP with The Gambia's national strategies and

²⁰ All planned projects were implemented.

development plans. The Bank's sector interventions were also closely aligned with sector-specific priorities. For example:

- **Agriculture:** Interventions were consistent with the National Agricultural Investment Plan, National Rice Development Strategy, and broader food security and poverty reduction frameworks. More specifically, agriculture interventions prioritized value chain development, rice self-sufficiency, and climate-smart practices, in line with sector investment plans and national strategies.
- **Transport:** Interventions addressed infrastructure upgrades and regional connectivity, as set out in the National Transport Policy.
- **Governance:** Support aligned with the NDP and the country's ongoing PFM strategies, the most recent one of which covered the period 2021–2025.

The evidence also showed that the Bank's engagement in The Gambia reflected its high-level corporate priorities, including the High 5s (particularly Light up and Power Africa, Feed Africa, Integrate Africa, and Improve Quality of Life for the People of Africa). Transport, energy and agricultural projects notably promoted regional integration, trade, and market access, directly supporting the "Integrate Africa" priority.

The evaluation found that the Bank's country strategies and interventions generally considered beneficiary needs, including those of disadvantaged groups, at the design stage, as confirmed by documentation reviews, surveys, and interviews. However, targeting strategies and criteria for identifying beneficiaries often lacked clarity and consistency. The CSP aimed to support socioeconomic transformation and resilience by creating decent jobs and addressing fragility, which aligned with beneficiary needs across the portfolio. Most interventions across sectors prioritized vulnerable populations. For example, **Agriculture** interventions focused on smallholder farmers, women, youth, and food-insecure households through capacity building and market access. Similarly, **Transport** interventions supported improved rural connectivity and access to markets, although some infrastructure gaps remained. **WASH** interventions targeted rural and peri-urban communities for safe water and sanitation, using participatory site selection to enhance inclusion.

However, **the evaluation found several limitations that reduced the overall relevance of the CSP.** These included the weak quality of some feasibility studies to inform intervention design (particularly in the transport sector), insufficiently developed targeting strategies, limited consideration for the private sector's needs and priorities as envisaged in the program theory, and limited Bank coordination in addressing changing circumstances related to the Banjul Port 4th Expansion Project, an important country priority.

4.1.2 The Design and Quality of CSP Formulation

The evaluation found that the design of the CB/CSP, and of interventions across all sectors, were informed by wide-ranging consultations with the government, civil society, and development partners, and generally aligned closely with national priorities. In the WASH and agriculture sectors, for example, the Project Appraisal Reports (PARs) showed that there were consultations with final beneficiaries, from village committees to farmer organizations. In transport and energy sectors, final beneficiaries were mainly consulted through Environmental and Social Safeguards (ESS) engagements.

However, while 90% of PCU/PIU respondents stated that intervention design had been based on extensive stakeholder consultation, some interviewees noted that lack of early engagement, notably in relation to ESS, had sometimes been an issue. Although ESS was incorporated into project design across interventions, the evaluation found notable gaps in monitoring and implementation, especially for infrastructure projects. Recent draft audit reports^{21,22} for the TGCP revealed further difficulties in maintaining compliance with ESS standards during implementation. While the PIU made commendable

²¹ Greenstad Projects Ltd. (Lead Consultant) & World Environmental Systems (Nig.) Ltd JV, 2025a. Environmental and Social Performance Audit Draft Report: Transgambia Corridor Project (TGCP) Phase I and Phase II. Prepared for the National Roads Authority, on 26 June 2025, provided to the Evaluation team on 16 August 2025.

²² Greenstad Projects Ltd. (Lead Consultant) & World Environmental Systems (Nig.) Ltd JV, 2025b. Resettlement Action Plan (RAP) Audit Draft Report: Transgambia Corridor Project (TGCP) Phase I and Phase II. Prepared for the National Roads Authority, on 26 June 2025, provided to the Evaluation team on 16 August 2025.

efforts to align with AfDB and national standards, compliance issues underscored the need for stronger monitoring mechanisms in future corridor projects, embedded in project design and planning.

The evaluation found that the Bank's efforts to mainstream cross-cutting issues, including gender and social inclusion, environment, and climate change, were clearly reflected in strategies and project designs and were consistently addressed throughout the period. While monitoring and outcome indicators were not always sufficient to fully capture results, the evidence showed that interventions in renewable energy, climate adaptation, and environmental and social safeguards contributed to a greener, more resilient development trajectory. Notably, the Bank's contributions that considered gender aspects were visible at both policy and operational levels, including its contribution to the development and launch of the national gender policy. Overall, the evaluation found that the Bank's approach to cross-cutting issues and capacity building aligned well with national priorities and demonstrated continuing relevance to evolving development needs.

4.2 Coherence

The coherence criterion examined the extent to which the Bank's interventions were aligned and coordinated both internally (across its own strategies, sectors, and instruments) and externally (with other actors, projects, and national priorities). Internal coherence is further explored through two dimensions: strategic and programmatic coherence, which assesses alignment with the Bank's overarching frameworks (CSP, CB, RISP), and operational coherence, which evaluates how well interventions reinforce each other in practice.

The evaluation found mixed results. While there were notable examples of alignment and coordination, gaps remained in translating strategic intent into integrated implementation. Nonetheless, the evaluation assessed overall coherence across the Bank's interventions during the review period as satisfactory.

4.2.1 Internal Strategic and Programmatic Coherence

Across all sectors (energy, WASH, agriculture, transport, and governance), the evaluation found that interventions demonstrated alignment with the core objectives of the CB, CSP, and RISP and collectively, aimed to contribute to socioeconomic transformation within the regional context. However, the evaluation often deemed the causal paths to achieving this goal unclear, and the results logic incoherent in several areas. This issue further complicated performance measurement of the program's achievements.

In agriculture, although the CSP emphasizes value chains linked to tourism and export markets, the evaluation found that interventions mainly focused on domestic crops such as rice and livestock. Export-oriented products such as groundnuts, cashews, fish, fruits, and vegetables received little attention. The program's emphasis appeared to be on agriculture commercialization for local consumption, with performance metrics centered on productivity and post-harvest losses rather than sales or processing. Stakeholders noted that local rice is consumed solely within the domestic market, which limits the potential for tourism-related sales. Furthermore, although food security was listed as an objective, the evaluation found that it received minimal focus during implementation, indicating inconsistencies between stated goals and actual activities.

In the WASH sector, although a project was already underway during CSP preparation, the evaluation found that its significance was not captured in the CSP's results indicators. The performance framework included the installation of 144 solar-powered water supply systems as an output but lacked corresponding outcome indicators on improved hygiene and human health.²³

The evaluation found that cross-sectoral linkages were well articulated in some interventions, particularly in infrastructure and energy, but were otherwise limited overall. For example, construction of the Senegambia Bridge under the TGCP was intended to connect agricultural areas to new markets and improve access to agricultural inputs, while energy sector projects aimed to support agro-processing industries through a reliable power supply. However, beyond these statements, the

²³ WASH was included as a cross-cutting issue in the CB.

evaluation found little evidence of deliberate design to make interventions mutually reinforcing across sectors. Governance was the only area where a modest multi-sector approach was evident. The emergency program-based operation (PBO) for COVID-19 included specific actions supporting health, social protection, and food safety, while the Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program (PFM-ERP) included specific actions related to energy, climate change, and food security.²⁴

Despite the CSP's stated emphasis on strategic focus areas with intersectoral linkages, the evaluation found that the portfolio largely evolved through separate, sector-specific initiatives. This reflects a gap between strategic intent and implementation, with limited operationalization of integrated approaches across sectors.

The evaluation also found that other coherence aspects related to the Bank's selectivity criteria were relatively well integrated into the portfolio. The Bank invested in areas where it had a comparative advantage; some (but not all) cross-cutting issues were mainstreamed; and the Bank successfully leveraged external funding sources, although opportunities for co-funding did not materialize on two occasions. **However, success in moving to fewer, larger interventions as part of the selectivity approach has remained mixed.**

4.2.2 Internal Operational Coherence

The evaluation found the interlinkages between the Bank's investment and non-lending activities to be satisfactory but also offering room for improvement, as these interlinkages remain unevenly articulated across sectors. Investment interventions benefited from support through the Bank's capacity-building and institutional-strengthening non-lending activities. Within each sector, the evaluation noted that interventions were largely coherent and mutually reinforcing, particularly where projects built on previous achievements or addressed identified gaps.

For example, in energy, the Gambia Electricity Access Project (GEAP) and the Gambia Electricity System Rehabilitation and Expansion Project (GESREP) are mutually reinforcing, with GEAP driving access-to-power expansion and GESREP helping to ensure that access is sustainable, technically robust, and reliably managed. The objectives of both projects complement the Gambia River Basin Development Organization (OMVG) Energy Project, which is providing electricity supply and a transmission backbone to integrate the country's electricity subsystems. WASH projects complemented each other by scaling up successful approaches and integrating capacity building. In governance, PBOs and Institutional Support Projects (ISPs) were combined to support PFM reforms. In transport, both operations (the TGCP and the now-stalled Port of Banjul Expansion Project) were intended to contribute to an enhanced multimodal transport system and to strengthen The Gambia's position as a regional transport hub.

Furthermore, the evaluation observed a portfolio-wide evolution over the period from mostly short-term crisis interventions, such as emergency PBOs, to longer-term, resilience-oriented investments. This shift reflected a growing emphasis on sustainability and inclusivity in the Bank's approach to development in The Gambia, although it remained unevenly articulated across sectors.

4.2.3 External Coherence

The evaluation assessed external coherence as satisfactory overall, but with mixed achievements regarding alignment, synergies, and mutually reinforcing activities with other partners and the government in implementing the Bank's program. The findings also indicated strong efforts to leverage resources and instances of coordinated interventions in some key sector activities.

The evaluation found that investments were generally well coordinated within sectors and, through the support of Project Coordination Units (PCUs) under sector ministries, were largely complementary, keeping duplication risks and overlaps to a minimum. In agriculture and energy, clear roles among development partners, often supported by co-financing, helped avoid overlap. For example, the Islamic Development Bank (IsDB) and the Arab Bank for Economic Development in Africa (BADEA) typically focused on infrastructure, while the Bank supported softer service components. In energy, the Bank, the World Bank, and the European Union (EU) coordinated effectively in support of

²⁴ More specifically, measures included the approval of a revised Port Bill and a Climate Resilient Fertiliser Policy by Cabinet and the development of a roadmap for farmer-based census by the Agriculture and Natural Resource Ministry. These measures had not been implemented at the time of this evaluation.

government programs. In WASH, partners were generally specialized by geographic focus, although challenges remained in coordinating with non-traditional actors such as non-governmental organizations (NGOs), civil society organizations (CSOs), and philanthropists. In governance, duplication risks were more apparent, particularly in technical assistance and training activities, underscoring the need for improved coordination and information sharing among development partners.

The evaluation identified important actions by the government, through the PCUs, to enhance program coherence by aligning donor-funded activities with national priorities and promoting synergy. For instance, the Ministry of Transport used intervention matrices to link projects with funders, and the Ministry of Finance's Central Project Planning Unit (CPPU) identified overlap with World Bank PFM support. Regional directorates fostered daily operational coordination in agriculture despite modest support from the Bank for sector planning and coordination, a situation linked to the Bank's physical absence from the country, as emphasized by interviewees.

Field visits conducted for the evaluation highlighted additional successful coordination, such as adaptive land use among the Agricultural Value Chains Development Project (ACDVP), International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), and IsDB projects, and combined funding that sustained women-led poultry initiatives. Nevertheless, these positive examples were tempered by challenges arising from weak donor coordination and duplication risks in some operations. For example, the lack of a shared beneficiary database led to repeated input distributions across the ROOTS²⁵, P2PRS²⁶, and GAFSP programs. In WASH, the Project Management Unit (PMU) coordinated EU system upgrades with Rural Water Supply and Sanitation Project (RWSSP) funds, but uncoordinated actions by some partners threatened groundwater sustainability.

The evaluation found that the Bank successfully mobilized additional resources over the period covered. The Gambia attracted additional resources from the Bank's Regional Operations (RO) Envelope, a mechanism that enables Regional Member Countries (RMCs) to augment their performance-based allocations (PBAs) to implement regional projects. The portfolio analysis showed that about 22.7% of financial commitments originated from external sources. Of this, 18.4% was provided through various trust funds, with the majority coming from the GAFSP Trust Fund (hosted by the World Bank and the International Finance Corporation [IFC]). Other contributing trust funds included the Global Environment Facility (GEF), the RWSSI Fund (hosted by the AfDB), the Sustainable Energy Fund for Africa (SEFA, also managed by the AfDB), and the Climate Investment Funds (CIF) Strategic Climate Fund. The OMVG Regional Project was co-financed with eight DPs, and of the project cost estimate for The Gambia of about UA 105.73m, the Bank's financing was just UA 3.75m. Taken together, the Bank's total financing for the three energy projects (OMVG, GEAP and GESREP) amounted to UA 31.35m out of a total cost estimate of UA184.64m, equivalent to a leverage ratio of 5.9.

At the same time, the evaluation found that resource-mobilization efforts faced constraints that limited success in co-financing and strategic partnerships in some cases. For example, in agriculture, both IsDB and BADEA (USD 10m) were expected to co-fund the RVCTP, but funding from the BADEA did not materialize. In WASH, the size of the Climate Smart Rural Water, Sanitation and Hygiene Development Project (CSRWASHDEP) amounted to UA 27m at project approval (compared with UA 4.7m for the RWSSP), owing to additional funding from the Green Climate Fund (GCF) and the GEF. However, the size of CSRWASHDEP had to be reduced by about half during implementation, as the assumed GCF financing (corresponding to nearly 50% of the initial project cost) did not materialize.

Finally, the evaluation found that donor coordination in The Gambia remained challenging. Stakeholder interviews and documentary evidence indicated that while donor mapping and stakeholder consultations took place during project appraisals, sustained collaboration throughout implementation was lacking. Survey responses corroborated this finding. Occasional meetings with development partners such as the IMF, the World Bank, and the EU did not ensure full program alignment, especially in the context of high staff turnover. Regular interaction with other agencies, such as IsDB or IFAD, was rare, and sector working groups were largely inactive. Notably, the Water and Sanitation Working

²⁵ IFAD: The Resilience of Organizations for Transformative Smallholder farmers in The Gambia (ROOTS Program) by IFAD: The main goal of ROOTS is to improve food security, nutrition and resilience of smallholder farmers to climate change in The Gambia.

²⁶ The P2-P2RS project in The Gambia is a component of the Program to Strengthen Resilience to Food and Nutrition Insecurity in the Sahel, which is designed to enhance food security and climate resilience in The Gambia, a partnership of AfDB and GoTG.

Group, supported by the United Nations Children's Fund (UNICEF), and a PFM working group had both ceased to meet in recent years.

4.3 Effectiveness

The effectiveness assessment examined the extent to which the Bank's interventions achieved their objectives, outputs, and outcomes, using a threefold approach. This approach was necessary to provide a fair and comprehensive assessment of the effectiveness of the Bank's program over the evaluation period, despite the shortcomings in performance measurement, monitoring, and reporting noted in earlier sections of the report.

First, the evaluation applied a simple performance-rating methodology to assess achieved results against the performance indicators and objective targets defined in the CB and CSP results frameworks (see Annex 2), as stipulated in IDEV's Evaluation Manual (see Annex 3).²⁷ Second, this CB/CSP-level analysis was complemented by project-level insights drawn from observations, contextual factors, and project-specific results gathered during field missions. This assessment examined the extent to which the Bank's interventions achieved, or were likely to achieve, the objectives, outputs, and outcomes targeted under the priority areas of the two strategic documents (infrastructure development, agricultural productivity, and governance), and their contribution to The Gambia's broader development objectives as outlined in the strategies and in line with the evaluation's reconstructed Theory of Change (ToC). Third, the evaluation considered the Bank's capacity-building initiatives, technical assistance, knowledge products, and overall cross-cutting priorities, which together contribute to the overall assessment of CB and CSP achievement.

Based on this threefold approach, the evaluation found that the program demonstrated varied effectiveness, and therefore a definitive overall rating could not be assigned. While CB/CSP-level indicators suggested uneven performance and supported a partly unsatisfactory rating, project-level achievements, knowledge products, and cross-cutting contributions delivered notable and, in some cases, transformative results across all three focus areas, despite contextual challenges and some unfulfilled ambitions. Taken together, these elements can thus be considered satisfactory overall.

Based on this threefold approach, the evaluation found that the program demonstrated varied effectiveness, and therefore, a definitive overall rating could not be assigned. While CB/CSP-level indicators suggested uneven performance and supported a partly unsatisfactory rating, project-level achievements, knowledge products, and cross-cutting contributions delivered notable and, in some cases, transformative results across all three focus areas, despite contextual challenges and some unfulfilled ambitions. Taken together, these elements can thus be considered satisfactory overall.

4.3.1 CB/CSP Performance Rating

Based on the analysis of reported results from Mid-Term Reviews and Completion Reports against the CB and CSP performance indicators in their respective results frameworks (RFs), the evaluation found overall performance to be partly unsatisfactory (see Tables 2 and 3, and Annex 2 for details). Across the three focus areas identified (infrastructure development, agricultural productivity, and governance), assessments using weighted averages of outcomes and outputs revealed mixed results.

Infrastructure development achieved 58.7% of its weighted targets, with relatively strong outcome performance (70%) compared with outputs (41.7%), reflecting the non-implementation of the One-Stop Border Post (OSBP) component. Governance and Public Financial Management recorded a similar weighted score of 54.3%, driven by high output achievement (85.7%) despite weaker outcomes (33.3%). In contrast, agricultural productivity and value addition performed poorly, with an overall

²⁷ IDEV, Evaluation Manual.

weighted achievement of only 8.6%, reflecting near-zero progress on outputs and limited outcome attainment (14.3%). These disparities underscored the uneven effectiveness of interventions across strategic priorities.

However, this quantitative analysis did not fully capture the changing context in which the CB and CSP were implemented. It also excluded a substantial number of indicators (30) for which neither targets, baselines, nor the results level (output/outcome) were clearly defined in the overall program RF or suited to the program's implied ToC. These issues, relating to a problematic RF and weak monitoring and reporting, were already noted in the Relevance and Coherence sections of this report.

Table 2: Performance achievement percentages by priority area

Category of target	Infrastructure Development (Transport, Energy, Water)		Agricultural productivity and value addition		Governance and Public Financial Management	
Outputs	5/12	41.67%	0/2	0.00%	12/14	85.71%
Outcomes	7/10	70.00%	1/7	14.29%	2/6	33.33%
Weighted Percentage²⁸	58.67%		8.57%		54.29%	

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

Based on this analysis, the evaluation rated infrastructure and governance interventions as partly unsatisfactory, and agricultural productivity as unsatisfactory. Overall, the aggregated CB/CSP performance was assessed as partly unsatisfactory, reflecting both achievements and gaps in meeting intended outputs and outcomes against the CSPs' results framework (see Table 3 below).

Table 3: Performance ratings by priority area

Category of target	Infrastructure Development (Transport, Energy, Water)	Effectiveness in Agricultural productivity and value addition	Effectiveness in Governance and Public Financial Management
Outputs	Partly unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Satisfactory
Outcomes	Satisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory
Weighted Percentage²⁹	Partly unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Partly unsatisfactory

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

The evaluation found that these ratings provided only a partial picture. They do not account for contextual or program changes, incomplete indicators, or progress toward targets that were not fully achieved. For example, as is evident from the evaluation's portfolio review, the nine implemented interventions under the CB 2017–2020 surpassed the four initially planned interventions in the IOP. In contrast, under the CSP 2021–2025, two of the seven planned interventions were not implemented, but the total number of interventions (11) exceeded the seven initially planned.

In particular, the infrastructure development focus area was affected by changes in government priorities, which led to several target results in the CSP framework losing their relevance to the country's evolving strategic needs and being *de facto* dropped, without the RF being updated to reflect this. For example, under the Banjul Port 4th Expansion Project, shifts in government priorities for the port resulted in the removal of specific project components and a narrowing of the project to supporting jetty enhancement only. As a result, the original output and outcome indicators were reported as not achieved. In addition, delayed implementation, the reallocation of resources, and limited resources hindered the full realization of expected outcomes. Consequently, the results did not translate into adequate country-level impacts.

²⁸ Weighted Percentage is the weighted average of Outputs (40%) and Outcomes (60%).

²⁹ Ratings are according to the IDEV Manual for Performance Ratings: Highly Satisfactory (100% achievement or above), Satisfactory (70–100% achievement), Partly Unsatisfactory (40–70% achievement), and Unsatisfactory (below 40%).

4.3.2 Project-Level Results

The CB and CSP achievements discussed above only assessed indicators as “fully achieved/exceeded” or “not achieved”. They did not reflect areas where progress was substantial, underway, or likely to be achieved. In addition, several individual Bank interventions appeared to contribute to CB/CSP-level results, even though they are not explicitly mentioned in the strategic documents. To capture these aspects and other nuances uncovered during field missions, the evaluation also examined the extent to which project-level activities and results contributed to the overarching objectives of the CB/CSP and to the focus areas defined in the reconstructed ToC.

Infrastructure development (transport, energy and water)

The evaluation assessed the delivery of outputs and outcomes in individual energy, water, and transport interventions in support of the strategic goal of strengthening infrastructure development to enhance agricultural productive capacity, competitiveness, and value chain development. In addition, although not always reflected in the CB/CSP RF, overall intervention objectives often aimed to contribute to laying the foundation for socioeconomic transformation and resilience. Considering the changes to program and project composition over the evaluation period, the real-time field evidence collected by the evaluation for the infrastructure development pillar demonstrated performance consistent with a satisfactory rating.

Through transport interventions, the Bank sought to address infrastructure weaknesses and improve market access for agricultural producers both within The Gambia and across borders.

This objective was particularly exemplified through the Trans-Gambia Corridor Project (TGCP, Phase I and II), which served as a vital economic and strategic link between the northern and southern regions of both The Gambia and Senegal and supported cross-border connectivity through the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) and the Dakar-Lagos Corridor. Inaugurated in 2019, the TGCP bridge and its access roads replaced an inefficient ferry system (see Technical Annex for a Summary of the Case Study).

The evaluation found that rehabilitation of the Farafenni-Senoba Road greatly facilitated the movement of people and goods within The Gambia and between The Gambia and Senegal. This was evident in the sharp rise in traffic volumes along the road, with Annual Average Daily Traffic (AADT) increasing from 1,027 vehicles in 2011 to a projected 4,777 vehicles in 2025. By its completion in 2019, traffic on the Senegambia Bridge had increased 3.5 times, reaching an AADT of 1,881 vehicles compared with 532 vehicles in 2011 through the ferry crossing, far exceeding the initially expected increase of 5% by 2016.

The evaluation also found reduced transport costs, which declined from EUR 3.6 per km to EUR 0.30 per km in 2025, reaching 86% of the target of EUR 0.26 per km. The cost-benefit analysis further showed that travel times dropped significantly, from about 79 minutes using the ferry (including 45 minutes of waiting) to just 1.5 minutes by bridge in 2019 (100% of the target; see results details in Technical Annex 8). These achievements underscore the Bank's contribution to regional integration, market access for agricultural producers, and strengthened infrastructure to support value chain development.

However, the evaluation also found that some planned components, such as the OSBP, remained incomplete, and opportunities to further improve market access for agricultural products were missed because of unanticipated implementation challenges. These challenges led to the reallocation of funds toward bridge and access-road construction as the main purpose of the intervention. Despite these gaps, the evaluation found that the TGCP's positive impact on connectivity and trade facilitation was clear.

The evaluation found that energy-sector interventions achieved notable results and were well on track to meet outcome targets for the ongoing operations. The Bank's energy interventions contributed to improved access to clean electricity and expanded transmission capacity, increasing the share of renewable energy in the national supply from 2.1% in 2021 to 5.25% by the fourth quarter of 2025, slightly above the 5% program target. The projects delivered most of their planned outputs, with some activities ongoing and judged likely to be achieved, including the potential to create an enabling environment for future private sector investments in rural areas and for electricity access for agricultural producers.

For example, the evaluation found that the interventions were likely to boost new generation capacity to more than 150 MW, surpassing the original goal of 144 MW, as the OMVG regional transmission line

enabled plans for a 150 MW solar plant. The first 50 MW phase was already under tender.³⁰ In addition, The Gambia's first privately owned mini-grid was co-financed by the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) and the Unique Group under the Sustainable Energy Fund for Africa (SEFA), although mini-grid development and access remained limited compared with grid expansion.

In the WASH sector, only one of the CSP-level results indicators corresponded directly to the Bank's WASH interventions, as the CB RF did not adequately define baselines and targets. The Bank invested around UA 1.3m (2% of its portfolio) through two WASH interventions and two non-lending activities, focusing on increasing access to potable water and sanitation through solar-powered water systems. The evaluation found strengthened institutional and community capacity, illustrated by the establishment of a new ministry office and support for WASH mapping and monitoring.

As noted earlier in the report, the CSP performance framework did not include an outcome target for WASH but set an output target of 144 solar-powered water supply systems. While the 2025 Completion Report and 2024 Country Portfolio Performance Review (CPPR) stated that no such systems were installed, project site visits by the evaluation team revealed that 73 systems had in fact been completed: 15 under The Gambia Rural Water Supply and Sanitation Project (RWSSP) and 58 under the Climate Smart Rural WASH Development Project (CSRWASHDEP). The original target was revised to 68 because of a 50% funding cut in CSRWASHDEP, and the evaluation found that this revised target had been exceeded.

In addition, all RWSSP infrastructure goals were fully achieved, including 1,000 household latrines. Most CSRWASHDEP works were finished or near completion, and a concept note for Phase II has been submitted. Based on this evidence, the evaluation judged that RWSSP outcome targets were fully achieved, with the new infrastructure supplying water to the target population of about 65,000 people and providing latrines to 19,750 people (slightly below the 20,000 target). An important aspect of WASH interventions was the support and training provided to village committees, which the evaluation found to be a key factor for sustainability.

Modernized Agricultural Value Chains as CSP Outcome Objective

In contrast to the CB/CSP-level analysis, **the project-level evidence found that Bank-financed agriculture interventions delivered achievements that contributed to the CSP's strategic objective of modernizing agricultural value chains in the targeted regions.** Field-visit data, interviews, and focus group discussions with beneficiaries corroborated documentary evidence indicating that the interventions contributed to modernization of key segments of the value chain, improved productivity, strengthened market linkages, enhanced food security, and increased rural incomes in the targeted communities. **However, achievements fell short of expectations.**

The evaluation assessed nine operations, with a value of UA 90.57m (30.8% of the portfolio). Overall, projects achieved 70% of expected outputs and 60% of expected outcomes, a weighted average of 64%, consistent with a partly unsatisfactory rating. Performance varied across interventions, and some targets, such as those on commercialization and land development, were not fully met (see program results data in Technical Annex 8).

The evaluation noted positive contributions from the Bank's programs to strengthening the agriculture sector and value addition. This was most evident in the introduction of a certified rice-seed production system and the creation of new market linkages, particularly among peri-urban and rural communities through the RVCTP in Central and Upper River Regions (see Box 1), and the Home-Grown School Feeding (HGSF) Program implemented across all regions. The evaluation found that HGSF, financed under the GAFSP Trust Fund, was particularly effective in supporting the education sector. It increased school attendance among children by 34%, reduced the proportion of schoolchildren reporting stress by 20%, and lowered dropout rates during the school year by 6%.³¹ These achievements demonstrated how agricultural interventions extended beyond productivity gains to deliver social and human development outcomes.

³⁰ NAWEC informed the Evaluation Team during the Data Collection Mission of May 2025 that there is an ongoing tender under WB financing for the first phase of 50 MW Solar Power Plant of a planned 150 MW regional IPP.

³¹ Barro, D., Bogaards, C., Christian, P., Heirman, J., Kelley, E., Khincha, R., Kondylis, F., La, M.P., Lane, G., Lerva, B., Lombardini, S., Zwager, A. (2025). Impact Evaluation of the Home-Grown School Meals Programme in The Gambia. World Food Programme Office of Evaluation.

At the same time, the evaluation found that no food crops except rice achieved their productivity targets. At the project level, resources were systematically shifted toward rice as the most important staple for reaching food sufficiency in the targeted regions and in response to the Government of The Gambia (GoTG) requests to prioritize rice as a key need at the time. This shift underscored rice's heightened significance in achieving the CSP's strategic objectives.

Other examples of project-level achievements that contributed to CSP objectives included the following:

- **The Food and Agriculture Sector Development Project (FASDEP)** focused on promoting agro-enterprise development and value addition to strengthen agricultural commercialization. The evaluation found that it slightly exceeded its target by supporting 122 agro-enterprises (against a target of 120) through matching grants for mechanization, processing, and production. These grants enabled smallholder farmers and rural entrepreneurs to invest in equipment and technologies that improved efficiency and reduced post-harvest losses. The project also contributed to job creation and income growth, particularly for women and youth engaged in agribusiness. While the evaluation could not fully verify all reported reductions in post-harvest losses, stakeholder interviews indicated that FASDEP interventions improved market access and strengthened local value chains.
- **The Agricultural Value Chain Development Project (AVCDP)** aimed to increase productivity and commercialization of rice and livestock while improving rural livelihoods by doubling agro-entrepreneur incomes from GMD 1,000 in 2015 to GMD 2,099 as of December 2023, according to project records. The project delivered critical infrastructure, including water points for cattle and poultry markets, which supported livestock production. As a result, the evaluation found that livestock output in the Upper River Region increased by 33% and that poultry and small-ruminant producers doubled their incomes, contributing to household resilience and food security. On the crop side, AVCDP supported rice commercialization and value addition, although progress was slower than anticipated due to delays in land-development and irrigation works. Despite these constraints, the project strengthened smallholder capacity and provided matching grants that enabled farmers to adopt improved practices.

Despite these project-level achievements, the evaluation found that the ambition to modernize agricultural value chains for inclusive growth, as articulated in the CSP's single strategic pillar, has not been fully realized at the program level. The Bank's interventions in the agriculture sector generally concentrated on the production segment of the value chain, with limited engagement in other critical segments such as processing, trading, wholesaling, and retailing. One exception was FASDEP, which provided matching-grant support to both crop and livestock value-chain actors in mechanization, agro-processing, and production.

In addition, the evaluation found that considerable delays in implementing the agricultural infrastructure component, due to inadequate time and resource estimations, adversely affected improvements in rural incomes. Moreover, although the portfolio offered strong opportunities for synergies across agricultural projects, the evaluation found little evidence that such synergies were realized.³²

Box 1: The Rice Value Chain Transformation Project

The Rice Value Chain Transformation Project (RVCTP) was designed to transform the rice value chain by increasing commercial rice production and strengthening seed systems. The project introduced certified seed production systems and fostered partnerships between public institutions, such as the National Seed Secretariat and the National Agricultural Research Institute, and private agribusinesses, such as Maruo Farm and Sahel Agribusiness. The evaluation found that RVCTP stands out for catalyzing systemic change, fostering a shift among farmers toward market-oriented rice production, and supporting the breeding and dissemination of improved rice varieties. While the target of increasing commercial rice production from 0% to 30% was not met, the 15% increase achieved still represented significant progress, and productivity nearly doubled from 2.2 t/ha to 4 t/ha in the Central and Upper River Regions. These gains were supported by Farmer Field Schools and improved irrigation infrastructure, which enhanced farmers' technical capacity. Although some

³² In principle, REWARD can build on the gains of RVCP through equipment, capacity building or establishment of farmer field schools. The Home-Grown School Feeding component of the GAFSP can procure rice from farmers that were previously supported by the RVCP, while the RVCP benefits from the land prepared under FASDEP and AVCDP. However, as observed during the field visit, farmers targeted under GASFP were not the same farmers targeted by RVCDP. This decision was driven by equity, according to interviews with PCU.

infrastructure delays limited dry-season production, the evaluation found that the project's contribution to modernizing the rice value chain and improving food security is substantial, as confirmed by stakeholder interviews in the field and by monitoring data.

Economic Governance and Public Financial Management

Overall, the evaluation found that this strategic focus area of the program performed partly unsatisfactorily, despite some achievements in the Bank's key interventions. At project level, operations achieved on average 46% of expected outputs and 62% of outcomes, a weighted average of 55.6%. At the same time, the evaluation noted that several operations reported additional indicators as at least partially achieved, which was not reflected in the CB/CSP-level analysis.

At project level, the evaluation found that coordinated support from the Bank and other partners (the World Bank, the IMF, and the EU) was essential for the country during the 2016–2017 transition. This coordinated support was also vital for economic stability and reform progress during the 2020–2021 pandemic, helping to maintain the CSP's strategic focus on addressing governance and economic management.

For example, the Governance Emergency Budget Support (GEBS) Initiative and the COVID-19 Crisis Response Program-Based Operation were both assessed as satisfactory overall by IDEV's Project Completion Report Evaluation Notes (PCRENs), which emphasized that results were positive in terms of organizational and policy-related changes, although the operations underperformed against budget performance indicators. Key achievements included increased budgets for the health and education sectors (exceeding the target of zero change), expenditure reductions through the termination of more than 3,000 "ghost workers" (no target was set), 74% achievement in increasing revenues from previously uncaptured resources (GMD 506m compared to targeted GMD 683m), and the operationalization of (i) the Treasury Single Accounts (TSA), (ii) a PFM Coordination Committee and strategic action plan, and (iii) a debt management committee.

However, shortfalls in these programs included an inability to fully reform policies related to vehicle fleet and related asset sales, incomplete State-Owned Enterprise (SOE) oversight activities, limited progress in reducing the budget deficit, and the inability to improve on CPIA and PEFA indicators.

The evaluation found that more recent PBOs, such as the Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program (PFM-ERP), included specific actions related to energy, climate change, and food security (ref. footnote 24). PFM-ERP improved budget outturn performance in key areas such as reducing the debt-to-GDP ratio from 82% to 73.5%, exceeding the target of 78%. Nonetheless, longer-term outcome indicators related to indexes for government effectiveness and financial management performance remained underachieved.

Another key example of the Bank's governance support was the upgrade and implementation of the Automated System for Customs Data (ASYCUDA). The evidence found that The Gambia's customs administration benefited significantly from financial and technical assistance to transition from an ASYCUDA++ to an ASYCUDA World customs system. Operationalized through the Debt Management and Domestic Revenue Institutional Support Project (DMDR-ISP), the project recorded a 36.4% increase in government revenues, compared with the 7% target.

Later, through PFM-ERP, revenue mobilization from customs continued to increase from GMD 6.24bn to GMD 11.59bn, compared with a target of GMD 7.03bn. Through critical investments in outputs such as procuring hardware, customizing software, and providing comprehensive training to staff of the Gambia Revenue Authority (GRA), the Bank facilitated a successful move to the web-based ASYCUDA World platform. Feedback from users and beneficiaries indicated that the upgrade improved the efficiency and effectiveness of customs operations by reducing clearance times and increasing transparency. However, despite ASYCUDA World being operational at major entry points, the evaluation found that full integration with other government agencies, including immigration, police, and health, remained incomplete.

The evaluation also found reliable debt-management efforts and progress in PFM reforms, although the relevant PEFA scores were not comparable across the period. The Bank delivered its planned technical support and training to the Ministry of Finance's Directorate of Debt Management (DLDM) as expected, helping staff use Meridian software, draft the Medium-Term Debt Management Strategy (MTDMS), conduct debt sustainability analyses, and plan borrowing activities. More than 80 DLDM and GRA staff received training, of whom 40% were women, compared with an original target of

10 staff (five of whom women). This assistance supported advances such as a new PFM Act and SOE audits and strengthened staff capacity for independent debt analysis.

The evaluation also found that financial-system integration and digital procurement progressed as planned, and the number of ex-post reviews of procurement processes reached 127% of the target. However, institutional capacity, budget credibility, debt sustainability, and SOE performance remained problematic. PEFA scores for PFM remained low. PFM-ERP targeted an improvement of the debt-management PEFA score from B+ to A, but because of revisions to the PEFA methodology between the 2011 and 2016 frameworks, the 2022 assessment rating was not comparable to the baseline.³³

The analysis of project results showed that the Bank's efforts to enhance the business environment and support private sector development fell short of expectations. Under the Inclusive Growth Promotion Institutional Support Project (IGPISP), six of 11 planned outputs were delivered, reflecting numerous changes in expected project outputs and activities over the project's lifespan that were not updated in the RF. At the same time, the evaluation found that all outcome indicators were achieved, with two of the four outcomes surpassing their initial targets³⁴.

The most notable output was the permanent Trade Fair Centre, which hosted 1,500 small and medium enterprises (SMEs) in local and regional fairs, compared with a target of 1,000, largely co-funded by the Government of India. Other results were more limited in scope, especially those arising from short-term training initiatives (for example, with the Financial Intelligence Unit and the Gambia Public Procurement Authority [GPPA]). Nevertheless, the project achieved or exceeded its targets to increase the number of new investments from 20% to 50%, increase the number of reported financial-crimes cases from four to nine, increase the private sector's credit share from 3% to 5%, and increase the number of registered suppliers for public procurement from 80 to 100.

However, the evaluation found that concerns about transparency and fairness in procurement processes remained. Efforts to increase private sector lending and develop capital markets faced delays and setbacks, including the suspension of support to the Gambia Women's Finance Association. Efforts to advance capital-market development similarly encountered delays stemming from legislative issues. Collectively, these mixed and, at times, stalled progress suggested that the Bank's projected improvements to the business climate and private sector growth had yet to be achieved and were unlikely to materialize in the near term. The evaluation therefore concluded that the Bank's most notable effects on private sector development were in agriculture, where capacity-building and financial programs benefited small agribusinesses and selected commercial farms.

4.3.3 Capacity Building, Knowledge Products, and Cross-cutting Issues

The non-lending program set out in the CB and CSP sought to strengthen the Bank's technical and knowledge advisory role in The Gambia to improve quality at entry, catalyze future lending opportunities, support implementation capacity, and inform policy dialogue. The evaluation found that resource constraints and shifting priorities meant that not all studies and technical assistance were equally effective.

Capacity Building

The evaluation found that the Bank's capacity-building efforts were valuable but could have benefited from better streamlining. While both the CB and CSP emphasized strengthening government institutions, persistent institutional capacity challenges remained. Capacity building was integrated into most interventions and served as a central component of the Bank's support, even when it was not explicitly labeled as a cross-cutting issue.

Public institutions such as the GRA, National Roads Authority, the PPP Directorate, and the National Audit Office all benefited from training and financial support, particularly within governance operations. Similarly, capacity-building activities for the National Water and Electricity Company (NAWEC) were included in energy operations, and private sector actors and agricultural research bodies received capacity building within the agriculture portfolio. Projects targeted smallholder farmers, women-led SMEs, and youth through initiatives aimed at improving market access and institutional performance.

³³ As part of the transition from PEFA 2011 indicator PI-17 on Budget Predictability, Execution and Controls was split into different indicators under the 2016 Framework, specifically 2016 indicators PI-13 and PI-21.

³⁴ Due to multiple project extensions from 2020 to June 2025, some of the outcome indicators were noted achieved quite a while ago and should have been revised upwards to align with changes to the outputs and activities.

However, the evaluation found that criteria for prioritizing actions or beneficiaries were not always transparent and that capacity-building efforts in some sectors (for example, energy and transport) lacked sufficient depth to yield sustainable outcomes. **Overall, the evaluation assessed the results of the Bank's capacity-building work as mixed and observed that capacity challenges persisted because the Bank's interventions did not consistently include measures to sustain their benefits over the long term.**

Knowledge Work, Policy Advice and Dialogue

Portfolio and document analysis showed that the Bank prioritized its capacity-building efforts over the evaluation period not only through technical-assistance interventions but also through knowledge and advisory work. The evaluation found that the CSP envisioned three Economic and Sector Works (ESWs), two of which were completed. Furthermore, the CB delivered five out of seven ESWs before its completion. In total, this corresponded to an achievement rate of 70%.

In addition, the broader portfolio review noted the development of at least 20 knowledge products spanning all sectors. The evaluation found that more than half of the Bank's ESWs in The Gambia were deemed useful in program development and policy dialogue, based on an analysis of the extent to which the products informed program development or policy reforms. Key outputs included the Country Diagnostic Notes (2020, 2025), the African Economic Outlook report, the CPIA, private sector profiles, and resilience assessments. Two country focus reports were published: "Support and a Just Energy Transition" (2022) and "The Gambia: Driving Transformation—Reform of the Global Financial Architecture" (2024).

Additionally, a 2017 AfDB—World Bank Fragility Risk and Resilience Assessment informed early Bank engagements under the CB, and the evaluation noted the recent commissioning of the Gambia Human Capital Diagnostic Note, which the Bank intends to use to guide sector dialogue on human resource development, as an example of proactive use of ESWs. However, the evaluation could not fully determine the overall use and impact of ESW in strategic dialogue because of insufficient information and evidence.

Document analysis and interviews with key informants revealed that Bank-supported studies shaped intervention development across sectors. However, the evaluation found that inconsistencies in study quality sometimes resulted in design shortcomings, project delays, and costly revisions. Project Preparation Funds were effective in supporting agricultural projects in 2017 and the Banjul Port 4th Expansion in 2021, informing appraisals. In energy, Bank-supported feasibility studies for OMVG and Green Mini Grids guided location selection and rollout strategies and enabled the first off-grid Independent Power Producer (IPP) investment with USAID support.

Cross-cutting Issues

The evaluation found some progress in addressing cross-cutting issues, especially environmental and social safeguards, and some gains in gender equality institutionalization in certain sectors, although challenges persisted and results remained inconsistent overall. While the CB and CSP increasingly incorporated these issues into intervention designs over time, this did not always translate into clear planning or consistent implementation in funded programs. Technical Annex 7 summarizes how the Bank addressed cross-cutting issues in its programming and strategies.

The evaluation found that gender and social inclusion were consistently prioritized as cross-cutting issues in the CB and CSP throughout the period covered. The Bank's contribution to gender equality was most notable at the policy level and within the WASH and energy sectors, and more limited in other areas. Significant support was provided to the former Women's Bureau (now the Ministry of Gender) through capacity-building initiatives under the Institutional Support for Economic and Financial Governance III (ISEFG III) and PBO prior actions, facilitating the development and launch of a new gender policy. Despite some delays, this policy was adopted by Cabinet in 2025 and acknowledges the Bank's role.

In agriculture, the evaluation found that two of three gender-related indicators were achieved at the output level, although not at the outcome level, despite targeted assistance to women-headed households. At project level, under CSRWASHDEP, 10,270 women (of 19,750 beneficiaries) received improved latrines, and 33,800 women (of 65,000 beneficiaries) accessed safe drinking water, although precise targets were not available in the CB/CSP. Similarly, in energy, Bank-supported projects were expected to benefit up to 33,000 women-led households (15,000 via GEAP and 18,000 via GESREP) once electricity meters are installed and operational, although precise targets were not specified. The

direct impact of transport interventions on women remained unclear, as highlighted in the TGCP case study (see Technical Annex 6).

The evaluation found that progress had been made in mainstreaming environmental and social safeguards within Bank-supported projects in The Gambia, but that significant challenges remained. These challenges included delayed ESS integration in project implementation, capacity constraints, inconsistent stakeholder engagement, and weak institutional coordination. A review of project documents, consultations with SNSC and the National Environment Agency (NEA), and interviews with stakeholders pointed to challenges in meeting the Bank's environmental and social safeguards, as evidenced by low performance scores in certain projects (see **Error! Reference source not found.**2 below).

The Bank's updated Integrated Safeguards System (ISS), launched in May 2024, raised compliance standards. Despite major ISS trainings in Banjul in November 2023 and May 2025 for project managers and government officials, the evaluation found that structural and institutional challenges persisted. Effective ESS implementation relied on coordination with the NEA, which cited ongoing resource and capacity constraints, underscoring the need for continued dialogue between the Bank and the Agency.

Box 2: Overview of ESS Performance

Transport: The evaluation reviewed two draft audit reports for TGCP (ref. footnotes 21 and 22), covering ESS and Resettlement Action Plans (RAPs), and found that they rated the project as satisfactory and recorded substantial adherence to Phase I safeguards, while compliance during Phase II was only partial. Notably, no social safeguard officer was engaged during implementation, and on-site ESS expertise could not be verified, despite being a requirement for Category I projects. As a condition for first disbursement, these gaps resulted in delayed compensation for Project Affected Persons (PAPs), incomplete grievance logging, and the absence of annual performance audits until the final year.

While the PIU was deemed to have made commendable efforts to align with AfDB and national standards, the evaluation found that these compliance issues underscored the need for stronger emphasis on safeguards staffing and monitoring mechanisms in future projects, embedded into project design and planning. The ESS performance for the Banjul Port 4th Expansion Project, launched in May 2024, was rated unsatisfactory by SNSC due to non-compliance with ESS audit requirements and the delayed recruitment of an ESS specialist. Although an ESS specialist was eventually recruited, this occurred only after significant delays, and the evaluation found that reporting and follow-up on technical support recommendations were inadequate. The inadequacy of reporting could be attributed, at least in part, to ESS staff not having formal evidence that the Bank and the GoTG had agreed to cancel the ferry terminal from the port project.³⁵

Energy: The evaluation found that the GEAP project received a low ESS rating (an average of 1.5 out of 4) due to lack of thorough due diligence at appraisal and delayed ESS implementation. There were compliance issues with ESS requirements under the financing agreement, notably the non-submission of periodic reports before 2024, the absence of an ESS officer, and an unresolved grievance logged by a community, according to SNSC. These issues led to a challenging start to the project, although ESS performance improved progressively with Bank oversight since 2024. By contrast, the Green Mini Grids project was reported as having successfully implemented ESS measures, including stakeholder consultations and grievance mechanisms.

Agriculture: The evaluation found that ESS performance for agriculture projects in The Gambia, specifically under GAFSP and its additional financing, was rated satisfactory by the Bank. At the time of the evaluation, however, the agriculture portfolio relied heavily on NEA for ESS supervision due to a lack of in-house expertise within the Central Project Coordination Unit (CPCU). While Environmental and Social Management Plans (ESMPs) were prepared, their implementation and monitoring depended on regular collaboration between the Ministry of Agriculture, NEA, and AfDB. As a lesson learned from the initial phase, an ESS officer was to be assigned by the CPCU to the Project Management Unit (PMU) to address environmental and safeguards activities, indicating ongoing attention to ESS compliance.

WASH: The evaluation found that overall ESS performance in WASH interventions was compliant, with all required reports submitted and cleared by the Bank and no pending ESS issues at the time of reporting. The sector developed environmental and social management frameworks, including grievance mechanisms and labor-management procedures.

Source: Evaluation team field missions and stakeholder interview data

³⁵ Evidenced by e-mail correspondence of 13 March 2025 between SNSC and the AfDB project Task Manager, Subject: "P-GM-DB0-006 Gambia BANJUL PORT 4TH EXPANSION PROJECT [. . .] Need of evidence showing that Ferry Terminal has cancelled from the project".

4.4 Efficiency

The efficiency assessment examined cost effectiveness, resource use, timeliness, supervision and implementation progress reporting, monitoring and reporting systems, and overall portfolio performance. The evaluation also considered external coordination and partnerships and borrower capacity, which influenced efficiency alongside internal factors.

Overall, the evaluation found efficiency to be mixed. Positive findings included strong economic returns, timely project start-up in some programs, and improved portfolio performance indicators over time. At the same time, persistent challenges in implementation timeliness, procurement, supervision and reporting affected overall efficiency. The evaluation found that borrower performance was generally good and helped mitigate some delays, while partnership coordination was moderate and did not fully address systematic capacity gaps. These factors, combined with external shocks, shaped the efficiency rating. The evaluation also took into account the efforts made by the Bank and PCUs to work closely together to find remedial solutions in the face of disruptive situations during political transition and the COVID-19 pandemic, which contributed to delays.

4.4.1 Cost Efficiencies and Resource Use

Project-level analysis of selected agriculture and transport interventions found the cost-benefit analysis results to be generally positive, with satisfactory Economic Internal Rates of Return (EIRRs). For the TGCP, the cost-benefit analysis produced an EIRR of 24.3% for Phase I and 67.5% for Phase II, substantially exceeding the original forecast EIRRs of 18.6% (Phase I) and 17.4% (Phase II). FASDEP recorded an EIRR of 26%, above its baseline EIRR of 23%. Even though other projects, such as the RWSSP, recorded an EIRR of 17.6% against a baseline of 21.5%, and the AVCDP recorded an EIRR of 17.5% against a baseline of 35%, their EIRRs still exceeded the cost of capital (10% for RWSSP and 12% for AVCDP) in The Gambia. The evaluation therefore assessed these projects as satisfactory on cost-benefit analysis. Overall, the evidence showed that major investments have more than covered their costs and that scarce public sector resources were allocated efficiently, notwithstanding the delays recorded.

The evaluation also found good results in efforts to increase the resource envelope and utilization across the Bank's portfolio, notably by combining ADF grants with TSF resources to ensure consistency and broad coverage, especially in infrastructure and agricultural development. The evaluation noted strong resource mobilization and utilization, driven by the strategic blending of ADF grants with trust funds and co-financing arrangements.

The evaluation found that nearly all mobilized resources were utilized, with PCRs indicating an average utilization rate of 95.7% at project completion. In addition, at completion, most projects had achieved more than half of planned outputs within budgets, although some output targets were revised at Mid-Term Review (MTR) and many project implementation periods were extended. The evaluation also found that disbursements at project level improved from 40.6% in 2017 to 64% in 2024, peaking in 2021 with an annual disbursement rate of 66% despite the impact of the pandemic. These disbursement rates exceeded the CSP 2021–2025 target of 55%.

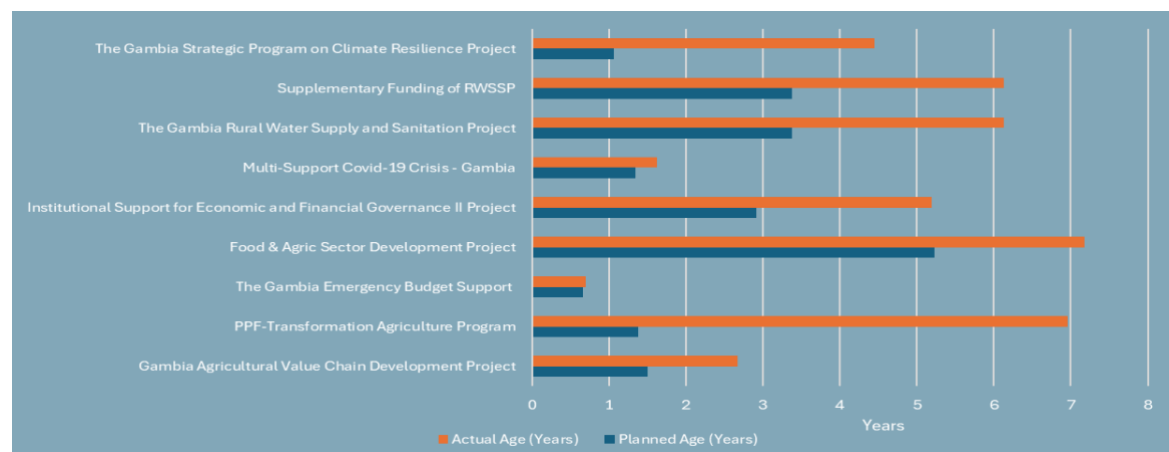
4.4.2 Timeliness

The evaluation found that project timeliness remained problematic, although it evolved in a positive direction over time, despite earlier challenges. While most projects began on time, they faced implementation delays, particularly the older projects.

Overall, 73.5% of projects in the evaluation portfolio (25 out of 34) met the timeline from approval to loan signature, and 88% achieved first disbursement within the required timeframe. However, analysis of the planned and actual duration of completed and closed projects shows that eight out of nine exceeded their expected time spans (see Figure 2). The gap between planned and actual duration ranged from one to six years. Seven of the nine projects required at least one extension, and six of the

nine had unsatisfactory PCR ratings on timeliness. The most extreme delays were observed in the OMVG Energy Project and TGCP Phase I, which remained incomplete after more than 10 and 14 years, respectively, far exceeding their planned durations of five and four years.

Figure 2: Planned and actual duration (number of months) for closed projects



Source: Established by the evaluation team based on project document reviews, including PCRs

4.4.3 Supervision and implementation reporting quality

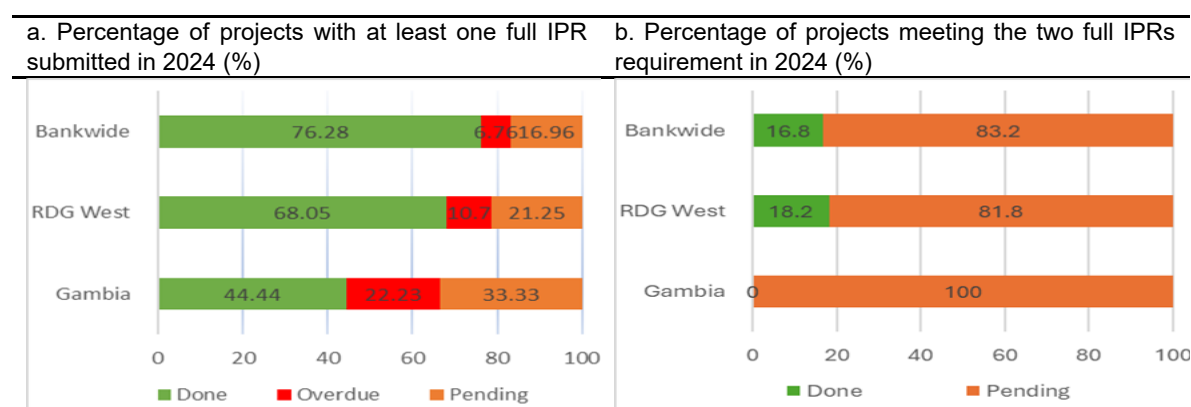
The evaluation found that Bank staff regularly engaged with local stakeholders and PCUs, although supervision frequency and reporting quality varied and often fell short of Bank standards. **Overall, the evidence indicated a significant shortfall in supervision and reporting on project implementation progress.**

On average, each project received fewer than one supervision mission per year, contrary to the Bank's requirement of two annual visits. This shortfall was reflected in the number of Implementation Progress Reports (IPRs) produced. A total of **46 IPRs** were generated, compared with an expected **132** based on the age of the projects calculated from the date of first disbursement. This discrepancy highlighted a systemic issue in monitoring, results reporting, and documentation.

Further analysis of PCRs for the nine **closed projects** reinforced this concern: the IPR ratings for these projects were deemed **unsatisfactory**, with an average score of **2 out of 4**, indicating weaknesses in project oversight and performance tracking.

A comparative analysis of IPR reporting in 2024 showed that The Gambia lagged behind both the RDGW region and Bank-wide performance. Only 44.44% of projects had at least one fully submitted IPR, and no project met the requirement of two fully submitted IPRs per year in 2024 (see Figure 3).

Figure 3: IPR Status of operations in The Gambia, compared with RDGW and Bank-wide performance



Source: Extracted from AfDB Delivery Dashboard on July 11, 2025

The evaluation found that the number of Back to Office Reports (BTORs) and aide-memoires for these same projects was even lower. This finding was confirmed by the **Project Results Assessment (PRA)**, which revealed a low frequency of supervision and poor quality of reporting of implementation activities and results, averaging just 0.5 missions per year. The COVID-19 pandemic further limited in-person oversight.

4.4.4 Monitoring and Evaluation (M&E) Quality

Despite the limited number of supervision missions, the evaluation found substantial evidence that Bank staff maintained regular engagement with program stakeholders and worked closely with PCUs and PIUs. This ongoing interaction helped sustain implementation momentum, even in the absence of frequent formal supervision. However, the evaluation also found that the effectiveness of results-based management was significantly hampered by weaknesses in project management indicators and limited attention to the quality of program results frameworks. Key issues included:

- **Lack of specificity.** Many indicators lacked well-defined baselines and target values. For instance, some CSP-level indicators used broad targets such as “improve governance,” which are difficult to measure objectively.
- **Poor definition and weak rationale for performance measurement.** Several indicators were not clearly defined, and their underlying rationale was not adequately explained, leading to inconsistent interpretation among stakeholders. In addition, in cases where adjustments to CSP indicators were required due to changes in program components and focus, these adjustments did not occur. For example, in the Banjul Port 4th Expansion Project, significant port expansion components were dropped because of shifting government priorities, but neither the CSP RF nor the financing agreement was revised. As a result, performance assessments concluded that related indicators were “not achieved.”
- **Absence of independent verification.** A large proportion of indicators relied solely on internal data sources, without external validation, which increased the subjectivity of progress assessments. The evaluation also found no attempt to converge toward sector-based performance data that could inform the CSP RF.

Regarding the quality of M&E arrangements for the projects, feedback from interviews and survey responses from PCU staff revealed **mixed perceptions**. Most staff reported having adequate capacity to collect and analyze data, but opinions varied on the clarity of project objectives and expected results. Notably, projects such as GEAP and AVCDP received divergent feedback concerning the structure and clarity of their results frameworks.

PRA reviews also confirmed infrequent and poor-quality monitoring and reporting. The evaluation found that many IPRs repeated previous content, indicating weak quality assurance. This undermined the credibility of the reports and highlighted systemic issues in project documentation.

The evaluation’s document review, survey, interviews with key program stakeholders, and site visits identified key implementation challenges that affected efficiency. The main factors contributing to implementation delays and efficiency constraints were as follows:

- **Project design challenges.** Some projects experienced design-related setbacks due to outdated or inaccurate technical assessments. For example, TGCP faced delays and a 30% cost overrun because of outdated geotechnical studies, which required redesigns and led to the cancellation of feeder roads due to budget constraints. Similarly, AVCDP encountered delays in land-development activities, primarily because of underestimated budgets and unrealistic timelines.
- **Procurement constraints and PCU capacity.** The evaluation found that procurement inefficiencies were widespread, particularly in grant-funded projects. Nearly 90% of grants involved an average of 15 separate procurement activities, significantly increasing the administrative burden. Delays in recruiting procurement officers, high staff turnover at the Bank, and a shortage of qualified contractors for both civil works and advisory services further hindered progress. Projects such as ISEFG III and IGPISP experienced slow disbursements and weak contract management due to inadequate procurement staffing. In agriculture-related projects, CPCU lacked in-house ESS expertise and relied heavily on external consultants, which affected effective ESS supervision and compliance during implementation.
- **Difficulties in paying government counterpart funding.** The evaluation found that difficulties in mobilizing government counterpart funding were common among agriculture operations and

contributed to delays in implementation. Similarly, in transport, under **TGCP**, contractors working on the Farafenni—Senoba Road segment refused to continue work because of outstanding government payments. According to a 2022 audit of TGCP, “the incomplete work at the swampy section of the highway is a breach of the contract agreement as all physical work is expected to be completed by February 2023.” At the time of the evaluation’s site visit, the evaluation team observed that roadworks remained incomplete, although this was not mentioned in project IPRs.

4.5 Impact

This section assesses the extent to which the Bank’s interventions contributed to higher-level goals at country level, including job creation for women and youth, food security, regional trade, access to basic social services, good governance and economic stability, climate resilience and environmental sustainability, and enhanced social and human capital.

The evaluation found that the Bank’s interventions contributed meaningfully to The Gambia’s development trajectory, with tangible results across **multiple sectors in access to electricity and water, support to trade and regional connectivity, and rural development**. The evaluation found that the Bank’s support was instrumental in helping the country navigate post-crisis recovery, build resilience, and lay the groundwork for inclusive and sustainable growth, despite a limited financial envelope. **Overall, the evaluation assessed impact as satisfactory, recognizing important results from TGCP (which had a transformational impact on regional connectivity, integration, trade, and economic development, although its potential effect on the local economy was not fully realized) and a positive trajectory under ongoing programs.** Most other Bank-supported interventions were relatively small in scale compared with the size of the overall economy. While this limited their potential for nationwide transformational impact, the evaluation found that these operations generated important economic benefits for target populations, including greater income-generation opportunities, improved food security, and better health and well-being for vulnerable groups, especially women and children, in the following areas:

- **Empowering vulnerable groups through jobs and inclusion.** The evaluation found that the Bank’s interventions created economic opportunities for youth and women and helped boost inclusion, particularly in the agriculture, energy, and WASH sectors. WASH projects improved access to drinking water for about 65,000 people and sanitation for about 20,000 people, enabling women and youth to engage in income-generating activities such as oyster harvesting and quarrying. Training initiatives increased employability, with 165 artisans (mainly youth) acquiring new skills. In agriculture, the evaluation estimated that nearly 200,000 people, including many women and youth, experienced increased incomes and improved food security. Projects such as the Gambia Agriculture and Food Security Project component and the Vulnerable Youth and Women Support Project contributed to reduced school dropout rates, enhanced livelihoods, and improved access to essential services for women-headed households. Targeted grants further empowered women-led agribusinesses.
- **Enhancing regional integration and trade.** The evaluation identified TGCP as a flagship intervention that significantly improved regional connectivity. The Senegambia Bridge and associated road infrastructure reduced travel time across the Gambia River from about 75 minutes to under two minutes, while trade with Senegal increased by 67%. The evaluation found that these investments positioned The Gambia as a strategic transit hub in the ECOWAS region.
- **Supporting governance and economic stability.** The evaluation found that the AfDB played a key role in strengthening PFM and macroeconomic stability, especially during the post-election recovery period and the pandemic years. Interventions such as the upgrade to the ASYCUDA World customs system contributed to a 23% increase in customs revenue. Other technical-assistance efforts supported debt management reforms and contributed to reducing the fiscal deficit and improving domestic revenue mobilization as a share of GDP, which was estimated to have increased to 13.49% from 12.16% in 2023.

4.6 Sustainability: Assuring longer-term benefits of the Bank's operations

The sustainability assessment examined the extent to which the Bank's interventions in The Gambia were likely to deliver lasting benefits beyond project completion. It considered technical soundness, financial sustainability, institutional sustainability, and environmental and social sustainability.

Overall, the evaluation assessed the sustainability of the Bank's operations in The Gambia as partly unsatisfactory, with the financial, institutional, technical and environmental dimensions all rated partly unsatisfactory. However, the evaluation also noted that the Bank's country team made several attempts to adapt and pilot novel solutions to address some of the sustainability issues highlighted below, with at least partial success.

The evaluation found that although sustainability measures were integrated at design and often effectively implemented in most programs, persistent gaps remained in financial, institutional, and environmental aspects across all sectors. These gaps limited the longer-term sustainability of interventions. The evaluation observed that strong ownership, capacity building, and community engagement contributed to lasting results. However, persistent challenges such as limited technical oversight, funding gaps, constrained fiscal space, and institutional weaknesses undermined prospects for durable results. More detailed sector- and project-specific sustainability concerns are presented in Technical Annex 10.

Technical sustainability was assessed to be partly unsatisfactory, with significant variability across sectors. On the one hand, energy and WASH projects generally employed robust, proven technologies and designs familiar to local actors, which supported continued maintenance of project outputs. On the other hand, agriculture and some transport components faced challenges related to non-operational or poor-quality infrastructure, including technical design issues identified in TGCP and certain WASH facilities, which may affect long-term sustainability.

Financial sustainability was assessed to be partly unsatisfactory. The evaluation found lingering financial risks, including fiscal constraints, affordability gaps for the poorest, and insufficient funding for road and infrastructure maintenance, particularly in agriculture and transport. In addition, mechanisms for mobilizing local revenue to ensure the upkeep and maintenance of project works and services after completion were often unclear in the context of the country's fragile fiscal situation. In the agriculture sector, for instance, the evaluation found that overdependence on development partner support and the absence of substantive government budget commitments to the institutions responsible for maintaining project benefits adversely affected sustainability.

Institutional sustainability was similarly assessed as partly unsatisfactory. The evaluation found that sustainability measures were promoted through capacity building, the training of local committees and artisans (notably in WASH and agriculture), and engagement with national agencies and PPP models in energy and transport. Despite these efforts, interviewees frequently reported high attrition among trainees and a high degree of aid dependency, which the evaluation considered as ongoing constraints on long-term institutional effectiveness across program interventions.

Environmental sustainability was found to be partly unsatisfactory. The evaluation highlighted that, although some progress had been made in integrating renewable energy (for example, through energy and WASH initiatives), climate-smart agricultural practices, and environmental safeguards across sectors, significant challenges persisted. Key initiatives such as promoting renewable energy and implementing climate-smart agriculture demonstrated progress, but gaps remained in effective safeguards implementation, contractor compliance, and the capacity to manage increasing resource demands and climate-related risks.

Field reports indicated that both climate change and population pressures were creating substantial challenges. Rapid population growth and rising immigration placed significant strain on water infrastructure, with existing borehole and tank capacity proving insufficient to meet demand. In agriculture, the evaluation found that climate change was compromising existing irrigation systems, necessitating ongoing upgrades to maintain productivity.

The evaluation also identified notable difficulties in the transport sector. Projects in this sector were generally rated unsatisfactory from a sustainability perspective, primarily because of a lack of specialist capacity and essential project resources, which resulted in delays in restoration activities and raised concerns about environmental resilience. Specifically, the evaluation found that TGCP received “satisfactory” ratings in draft ESS and RAP audits, but that these audits also acknowledged shortcomings identified during interviews, including the absence of dedicated environmental specialists, inconsistent reporting, and postponed restoration efforts. These gaps contributed to the deterioration of swamp-side road sections and drainage infrastructure, raising major concerns about the long-term environmental resilience of these investments.

Social sustainability, in contrast, was assessed as satisfactory. The evaluation found that social sustainability measures were incorporated at design and during implementation through community ownership, participatory approaches, and efforts to include women and vulnerable groups, particularly in WASH and agriculture operations. Energy and transport projects created jobs (partially monitored through IPRs) and contributed to improved livelihoods, although some interventions faced challenges with compensation, inclusion, and delayed stakeholder engagement, which limited broader social benefits.

For example, a draft RAP audit for TGCP found that the Phase II RAP was not implemented due to redesign and cost constraints, and no updated RAP was prepared to reflect actual impacts. The evaluation found that compensation to PAPs was delayed and grievance logging remained incomplete, limiting the project’s ability to mitigate adverse social effects. Nonetheless, the audit rated performance as satisfactory, because the PIU had undertaken ESS activities and made efforts to align with ESS instruments, despite limited capacity and resources.

5. CONCLUSIONS, LESSONS, AND RECOMMENDATIONS

5.1 Conclusions

The evaluation concludes that the Bank’s support to The Gambia between 2017 and 2024 yielded meaningful, but varied, results. Achievements and areas for improvement differed across sectors, thematic priorities, and beneficiary groups. However, constrained national capacity, limited resources, implementation challenges, and prevailing country conditions hindered the attainment of nationwide development impacts.

The Bank demonstrated agility and responsiveness in navigating major shocks, such as the 2017 political transition and the COVID-19 pandemic, working in coordination with other development partners and leveraging additional resources, both internally and externally, to respond to the country’s urgent needs and priorities. Its strategies and programs adopted a flexible and adaptive approach, building on previous achievements and tailoring interventions to meet the evolving needs and priorities of The Gambia and its beneficiaries. This supported continued relevance and responsiveness to the national context. At the same time, the evaluation identified several **operational areas that could have been strengthened, including the quality and application of feasibility studies, the adoption of a more realistic and integrated approach to program design, and enhanced performance measurement**. In addition, the limited scale and scope of interventions hampered the potential for greater impact across sectors.

The Bank’s interventions demonstrated varying levels of coherence, although they were deemed satisfactory overall. Internal coherence showed mixed results. Interventions aligned with strategic objectives, and non-lending operations helped maintain coherence within the program portfolio, but opportunities to realize cross-sectoral synergies were underutilized. External coherence was assessed as satisfactory, based on effective coordination with development partners at project level, the achievement of synergies and complementarities in key areas, and efforts to reduce duplication and mobilize resources. These positive elements coexisted with the absence of a more holistic, program-wide approach, persistent challenges with donor coordination, and potential duplication risks noted among competing donor focus areas in some programs.

The evaluation could not determine an overall effectiveness rating due to mixed results, largely driven by limitations in CSP performance measurement (including the lack of indicator updates

when priorities and intervention components changed) and weak monitoring and reporting.

While results against indicators in the CSP RF were deemed partly unsatisfactory, the evaluation found notable project-level achievements and additional contributions toward CSP objectives that the framework did not capture. Overall, the evaluation found that the Bank played a pivotal role by contributing to important development gains, although not at the desired scale. These gains included enhanced governance and macroeconomic stability, mobilization of resources to support infrastructure interventions in transport, energy, water, agriculture, and rural development, and increased economic opportunities for women and youth. Achievements such as the Senegambia Bridge, improved electricity and water access, and improved agricultural productivity among beneficiary communities contributed to the program's strategic focus and objectives. However, although infrastructure development and sector-specific outputs were substantial, efforts to reduce poverty, improve the business environment for private sector development, and strengthen agricultural value chains remained limited.

The evaluation found that factors such as accelerated and incomplete project designs, implementation delays, limited project monitoring and reporting, weakness in supervision, and constraints in government capacity to manage Bank projects, compounded by external events such as COVID-19, contributed to differences in project performance.

Cross-cutting issues, including gender, social inclusion, climate change, and environmental safeguards, received continued, albeit uneven, attention throughout the period covered by the evaluation, and mainly at the design stage. For instance, while CSPs paid increasing attention to these issues over time, this did not always translate into clear planning, consistent implementation of related measures, or optimal results in programs.

The evaluation assessed program efficiency as mixed. The Bank achieved effective resource utilization, high economic returns from infrastructure investments, satisfactory portfolio performance, and improvements in disbursement rates over the period. At the same time, implementation delays that extended project lifespans across the portfolio, driven largely by procurement challenges, staff turnover, and unforeseen disruptions during the political transition and the COVID pandemic, as well as weaknesses in monitoring and progress tracking, limited overall achievement.

The evaluation found that, although **sustainability measures were embedded in Bank-supported projects in The Gambia, major weaknesses persist.** Technical, financial, and institutional challenges such as quality concerns, high operational costs, and inefficiencies within agencies like NAWEC continue to undermine long-term impact. Progress through public-private partnerships is promising but incomplete, particularly while key legislation is still pending. Social sustainability is relatively strong because of gender and inclusion efforts, but environmental sustainability remains problematic because of climate risks and limited monitoring. Overall, sustainability was assessed as partly unsatisfactory, and the evaluation concluded that sustained reforms and stronger oversight are needed to ensure lasting benefits.

The evaluation deemed the **impact of Bank interventions satisfactory**, as evidenced by expanded access to services, enhanced regional connectivity, and increased economic activity, particularly through the Trans-Gambia Corridor Project (TGCP), which drove significant improvements in regional connectivity, trade, and economic development. In other sectors, most Bank-supported projects were modest in scale and scope relative to the national economy, which limited their capacity to drive nationwide transformation in broader social outcomes, such as poverty reduction. Nevertheless, evidence from field visits and beneficiary feedback confirmed that these initiatives generated tangible economic and social benefits, including increased incomes, improved food security, and enhanced well-being, especially among women and vulnerable groups in targeted areas. The Bank's success in leveraging additional resources and partnerships strengthened its financial footprint, with significant support from trust funds and the regional envelope.

The evaluation also found that the Bank has earned a reputation as a reliable partner in policy dialogue through high-level engagement and continued support for vital reforms. Despite missed opportunities for more intensive dialogue, partnerships, and coordination with key stakeholders and partners, as well as staffing challenges and a lack of physical presence over much of the period, the Bank remained a valued source of honest advice. It leveraged partnerships, regional integration, and capacity-building for stakeholders. The evaluation concluded that harnessing this foundation more systematically will be crucial going forward.

In summary, the evaluation found that the Bank's support has contributed to measurable progress across key sectors and to The Gambia's development, by advancing productive capacity, infrastructure, value addition, and governance; helping lay the foundations for

sustainable growth; and positioning the country as a potential regional trade hub. At the same time, the evaluation identified considerable scope for improvement. To achieve nationwide transformational impact and lasting progress, there is a need for stronger results-based program design, greater integration and scale of interventions, enhanced regional collaboration, improved business conditions, and reinforced sustainability. These improvements are essential to reduce poverty and raise living standards in a resilient and enduring way.

5.2 Key Lessons

Several factors contributed to the achievement of results. The evaluation found that a well-informed strategy that remained flexible, but still focused, was key to attaining critical mass, achieving important results at beneficiary level, and contributing to broader development objectives. Key lessons from the country program analysis include the following:

1. Maintaining strategic focus for results and impact requires balancing consistency and flexibility in the context of competing demands and limited resources.

The Bank's experience demonstrates the importance of maintaining a realistic, well-prioritized and clear strategic direction, while remaining adaptable to changing national priorities and external shocks, such as political transitions and the COVID-19 pandemic, in a context of limited resources and increasing demands. For example, while the CSP emphasized agricultural value chains, implementation included some unrelated projects, which contributed to fragmentation and missed opportunities for cross-sectoral integration and synergies. Future strategies should maintain a clear strategic direction, grounded in areas of comparative advantage, and be regularly updated to remain responsive and realistic. A focused approach, supported by co-financing and strong government engagement, will help ensure that resources are targeted and aligned, thereby maximizing developmental outcomes.

2. Government capacity and ownership are essential for enhanced performance.

Experience from the Bank's operations in The Gambia highlighted that project outcomes improve significantly when Project Coordination Units have strong capacity and when government ownership is genuine and sustained. The Bank's experience shows that, while improvements were made, especially in project performance, sustained government engagement and continued capacity-building, particularly in project management and the application of environmental and social safeguards, remain essential for optimal results.

For example, transport and infrastructure projects initially faced delays due to limited expertise in environmental safeguard compliance and inconsistent government involvement. Following targeted training for Project Coordination Unit staff and the establishment of regular review meetings with government representatives, the project saw marked acceleration in implementation and a reduction in safeguard-related issues. This case illustrates that investing in capacity building and strengthening government ownership throughout the project cycle leads to better-managed projects and more sustainable outcomes. At the same time, the evaluation found that institutional capacity limitations continued to constrain governance reforms in key PFM areas.

3. Effective private sector engagement requires contextual understanding and robust frameworks.

The Bank's experience in The Gambia shows that successful private sector engagement, including PPPs and support to small and medium enterprises (SMEs), depends on a sound understanding of the local context and clear legal and institutional frameworks. In The Gambia, unclear regulations and limited institutional capacity contributed to delays and missed opportunities. Better results were achieved where regulatory requirements were clear and institutional support was strong, enabling innovation and more effective risk management.

Tailoring interventions to the country's context clarifying and ensuring legal and institutional foundations are robust enough to support both innovation and risk mitigation led to greater effectiveness and market alignment. For example, previous attempts to launch private sector-focused operations faced hurdles due to unclear regulatory provisions and weak institutional capacities, which hindered project implementation and risk management. In one instance, "The combination of (i) changing prioritization

by the client, (ii) the lack of enacted PPP legislation, and (iii) insufficient responsiveness of the Bank towards development partners and insufficient information exchange(documentation), has caused some controversies domestically in The Gambia and in the Bank's relationship with other development partners including missed opportunities for investment, despite project feasibility and relevance."

4. Sustainability requires more than community involvement and training activities.

The Bank's experience underscores that while prioritizing community ownership and investing in capacity building enhanced the likelihood of project sustainability, these factors alone were not sufficient to guarantee long-term success. Ongoing challenges in funding and institutional support, along with leadership turnover, limited lasting impact. Effective sustainability requires secure financing, strong institutions, and clear post-project responsibilities in addition to community involvement and training.

For example, in WASH and some agriculture interventions, strong community participation and engagement with beneficiaries during planning and implementation led to improved local engagement and short-term maintenance of facilities through capacity-building activities. However, the evaluation found that insufficient financing, and turnover among trainees and community association leaders, affected continuity of support. This highlighted the need for sustainability strategies that go beyond community involvement and training, and that encompass secure financial provisions, robust institutional arrangements, and clear post-project responsibilities.

5. Effective and comprehensive strong M&E systems are crucial for accountability, results tracking and improved project and program delivery.

A key lesson is that a clear, externally validated M&E system is essential for accountability and accurate results tracking. Projects lacking well-defined indicators and consistent reporting tools struggled with performance monitoring, transparency, and timely corrective action. The evaluation's own experience in assessing program effectiveness further highlighted that changes in program activities need to be accompanied by corresponding revisions to results frameworks to ensure accurate performance and results reporting.

5.3 Recommendations

The following measures are recommended for consideration by the country team to improve the Bank's strategies, programs and operational performance in The Gambia in the coming years:

1. Building on previous achievements in infrastructure development, prioritize comprehensive, program-based strategies to advance progress and achieve nationwide impact.

The evaluation found that Bank infrastructure initiatives delivered notable results, contributing to regional connectivity and cross border trade, food security, and rural income enhancement. Interventions effectively addressed the needs of vulnerable groups, and flexibly targeted priority areas using diverse funding sources to complement the Bank's limited resource envelope. However, the benefits were found to be limited to the directly targeted populations, and programs could not achieve their desired country-level impact due to their individual approach and modest scale.

Actions to consider include:

- 1.1. Supporting investments and institutional reforms which have country-wide transformational impact, such as the development of economic corridors integrating rural and regional road networks, market access, rural electrification, environment and climate mitigation, and agro-industrial development.
- 1.2. Adopting a program-based approach to target key resources and partnerships for larger, integrated and higher-impact operations.
- 1.3. Continuing to enhance resource mobilization efforts through co-financing, innovative funding sources, PPPs and the regional operations envelope, while managing risks surrounding innovative funding and PPPs by ensuring that there is an adequate legal framework underpinning these efforts.

2. Enhance Governance and Public Financial Management support to address capacity weaknesses and improve performance of key public sector institutions.

Governance and PFM remain as key development challenges, despite significant capacity building and technical assistance contributions from the Bank and other partners. Key outcome indicators remain low, with persistent issues in institutional capacity, budget credibility, debt sustainability, and SOE performance. It is recommended that the Bank build on past efforts and continue to collaborate with partners, and to consider prioritizing the following actions:

- 2.1. Continuing to support efforts to improve public debt management and PFM, particularly those aimed at addressing weaknesses in institutional capacity.
- 2.2. Actively pursuing interventions that complement and synergize with other Bank development efforts and other development partners' capacity building and technical assistance activities.
- 3. Expand support for private sector development to accelerate the country's economic transformation, while aligning with the Bank's ongoing focus on enhancing PSD under its regional strategy.**

The evaluation found that progress in private sector development was limited, as the planned activities to improve the business climate and to support institutional capacity development were not fully achieved, despite the sector's continued importance for The Gambia's development priorities. Private sector development is considered a pillar for economic transformation, and the Bank may consider the following to expand its support:

- 3.1. Enhancing engagement in upstream activities, such as embedding policy dialogue and reform support within broader infrastructure and other sector interventions to ensure private sector benefits such as market friendly environment and enhanced access to finance are realized.
- 4. Strengthen dialogue with the Government of The Gambia and Project Implementation Units to address operational and implementation challenges, while considerably improving the Bank's project supervision, results monitoring, and reporting.**

The evaluation identified key factors affecting implementation and overall program performance, including weak monitoring and reporting, inadequate design quality, institutional capacity constraints in some sectors, procurement delays, frequent staff turnover and poor handover in both the Bank and government agencies, and external disruptions like the COVID-19 pandemic. Insufficient engagement due to resource constraints and limited physical country presence has limited the desired partnership and coordination with the Government, development partners, and key stakeholders.

Suggested actions may consist of:

- 4.1. Establishing a strong results-based M&E system to meet the Bank's information needs for program oversight, results monitoring and reporting, and strategic decision-making over the entire program cycle.
- 4.2. Ensuring that the designs of new operations are underpinned by solid feasibility studies, with clear consideration of the country context including institutional capacity.
- 4.3. Enhancing dialogue with the Government and coordination and harmonization of assistance with development partners through enhanced engagement, with adequate resources and country presence to support program planning, design, development and implementation.

ANNEXES

Annex 1: The Bank's Portfolio in The Gambia (2017–2024)

Project Code	SAP	Project Title	Status	Sources	Type	Approval date	Net Amount (Million UA)	Disbursement Rate (%) ³⁶
Agriculture and Rural Development								
P-GM-AA0-016		Rice Value Chain Transformation Programme	OnGo	ADF & TSF	Grant	12/6/2018	5.00	100.0
P-GM-A00-007		Incentive-Based Risk-Sharing System for Agricultural Lending Project	OnGo	ADF	Grant	11/8/2022	5.00	26.3
P-GM-AA0-018		Gambia Agriculture and Food Security Project	OnGo	GAFSP Trust Funds	Grant	10/12/2021	12.06	61.7
P-GM-AA0-014		Gambia Agricultural Value Chain Development Project (AVCDP)	COMP	ADF	Grant	3/31/2016	6.00	100
P-GM-A00-005		PPF-Transformation Agriculture Program	COMP	ADF	Loan	3/24/2017	0.93	100
P-GM-AA0-019		Additional Financing to the Rice Value Development Project	OnGo	TSF	Grant	7/15/2022	2.50	99.7
P-GM-AA0-013		Food and Agriculture Sector Development Project	CLSD	GAFSP Trust Funds	Grant	5/15/2013	20.04	100
P-GM-AA0-022		GAFSP Additional Financing	OnGo	GAFSP Trust Funds	Grant	3/4/2024	9.04	14.8
P-Z1-AA0-178		Gambia—Regional West Africa Resilient Rice Value Chains Development Program	APVD	ADF	Grant	11/20/2024	30.00	0
Environment								
P-Z1-C00-100		Project 2 of The Program to Strengthen Resilience to Food and Nutrition Insecurity in The Sahel (P2-P2RS)	OnGo	ADF	Grant	7/14/2023	12.50	14.0
P-Z1-C00-072		P2-P2RS—CILSS	OnGo	ADF	Grant	12/15/2022	5.00	10.2
P-GM-C00-006		The Gambia Strategic Program on Climate Resilience Project	CLSD	Strategic Fund Climate	Grant	7/27/2016	1.13	100
Finance								
P-Z1-HZ0-034		Africa Disaster Risks Financing Program	COMP	TSF	Grant	2/27/2019	0.90	93.5
Multi-Sector								
P-GM-K00-011		Institutional Support Project	COMP	ADF	Grant	9/23/2015	2.00	94.0
P-GM-KA0-009		Emergency Budget Support	CLSD	ADF	Grant	3/26/2018	5.00	100
P-GM-KF0-004		Debt Management and Domestic Revenue Institutional Support Project	OnGo	TSF	Grant	12/17/2021	1.00	95.9

³⁶ As of April 30, 2025.

P-GM-K00-013	Multi-Support COVID-19 Crisis—Gambia	COMP	ADF& TSF	Grant	7/24/2020	10.00	100
P-GM-KA0-011	Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program	OnGo	TSF	Grant	10/3/2023	5.00	100
P-GM-KF0-002	Inclusive Growth Promotion Institutional Support Project	OnGo	ADF	Grant & Loan	3/30/2017	3.67	79.4
	Power						
P-GM-FA0-002	The Gambia Electricity Access project (GEAP)	OnGo	ADF& TSF	Grant	10/8/2019	12.60	87.1
P-GM-FA0-004	The Gambia Electricity System Rehabilitation and Expansion Project (GESREP)	OnGo	ADF & TSF	Grant	7/14/2023	15.00	2.1
P-Z1-FA0-018	The Gambia River Basin Development Organization Energy Project (OMVG)	OnGo	ADF & TSF	Grant & Loan	9/30/2015	3.75	66.2
	Social						
P-GM-IBC-002	Horizons Clinic Gambia	TERM	ADB	loan	4/16/2014	6.18	0
P-GM-I00-003	Vulnerable Youth and Women Support Project	OnGo	ADF	Grant	9/14/2023	5.00	9.7
P-Z1-IBE-024	Gambia—Exceptional Project to support ECOWAS LICs and Strengthening the Health Systems to combat the COVID-19 Pandemic	OnGo	TSF	Grant	5/22/2020	2.50	30.7
	Transport						
P-GM-D00-008	ADF-PPF Advance Banjul Port 4th Expansion	COMP	ADF	Loan	8/9/2021	0.37	93.4
P-GM-DB0-005	Trans-Gambia Corridor Phase II	COMP	ADF	Grant	10/19/2014	1.00	100
P-GM-DB0-006	Banjul Port 4th Expansion Project	OnGo	ADF & TSF	Grant	12/16/2022	15.00	13.4
P-Z1-DB0-046	Trans-Gambia River Crossing Project	OnGo	ADF&EU-AIP	Grant	12/16/2011	76.27	46.8
	Urban Development						
P-GM-J00-002	Sustainable Urban Development Programme	COMP	TSF	Grant	3/26/2019	2.15	99.8
	Water Supply and Sanitation						
P-GM-E00-008	Addendum-PAR-CSRWASHDEP	OnGo	GEF-Global Facility	Grant	12/16/2022	6.74	64.1
P-GM-E00-003	The Gambia Rural Water Supply and Sanitation Project (RWSSP)	CLSD	RWSSI Fund & ADF	Grant	2/13/2012	4.36	100
P-GM-E00-006	Supplementary Funding of RWSSP	COMP	RWSSI Fund	Grant	3/15/2017	0.41	100
P-GM-E00-007	Climate Smart Rural Wash Development Project	OnGo	RWSSI Fund & ADF	Grant	9/17/2018	7.13	73.5

Annex 2. Output and Outcome Results at CSP Level

Summary Tables

Ratings are according to the IDEV Manual for Performance Ratings: Highly Satisfactory (100% achievement or above), Satisfactory (>70% achievement), Partly Unsatisfactory (>40% achievement), and Unsatisfactory (below 40%).

Weighted Percentage refers to the weighted average of Outputs (40%) and Outcomes (60%).

Performance Summary by CB/CSP

CB/CSP	Outputs	Percent	Outcomes	Percent	Weighted Percentage
CB 2017–2019	14/17	82.35%	7/10	70.00%	74.94%
CSP 2021-2025	10/20	50.00 %	6/16	37.50 %	42.50 %
Total	24/37	64.86%	13/26	50.00%	55.95%

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

Performance Ratings by CB/CSP

CSP/CB	Output Assessment	Outcome Assessment	Weighted Assessment
CB 2017–2019	Satisfactory	Satisfactory	Satisfactory
CSP 2021-2025	Partly Unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory
Total	Partly Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

Performance Summary Grouped by CB/CSP “Sectors”

Sector	Outputs	Percent	Outcomes	Percent	Weighted Percentage
Governance	12/14	85.71%	2/6	33.33%	54.29%
Agriculture	0/2	0.00%	1/7	14.28%	8.57%
Transport	3/8	37.50%	3/6	50.00%	45.00%
Power	2/4	50.00%	4/4	100.00%	80.00%
Health	2/2	100.00%	2/2	100.00%	100.00%

Sector	Outputs	Percent	Outcomes	Percent	Weighted Percentage
Cross-cutting Issues	5/7	71.43%	1/1	100.00%	88.57%
Total	24/37	64.86%	13/26	50.00%	55.95%

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

Performance Ratings by CB/CSP “Sectors”

Sector	Output Assessment	Outcome Assessment	Weighted Assessment
Governance	Satisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory
Agriculture	Unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory	Unsatisfactory
Transport	Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory
Power	Partly Unsatisfactory	Highly Satisfactory	Satisfactory
Health	Highly Satisfactory	Highly Satisfactory	Highly Satisfactory
Cross-cutting Issues	Satisfactory	Highly Satisfactory	Satisfactory
Total	Partly Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory	Partly Unsatisfactory

Source: Evaluation team estimates based on IDEV Manual methodology

A. Governance and PFM Output and Outcome Indicators 2017–2024

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Outputs			
CSP-Output	Financial audits completed and published (#)	5	10	10
CSP-Output	Ibrahim Index of Governance (0–100 points)	54.9	65	55.3
CB-Output	<i>New vehicle policy in place</i>	No	Yes	No
CB-Output	<i>Up-to-date position of the status of SOE finances and performance is compiled</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Stock-taking of contingent liabilities arising from SOE operations completed</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Basic performance contract is introduced between the government and at least 2 SOEs</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Continued support to the social sectors: Maintain budget execution for health and education ministries</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>A census is conducted to establish a complete inventory of central government (and other public sector) bank accounts at both the central and commercial banks. Based on this census, an action plan is established to restore the TSA</i>	No	Yes	Yes

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
CB-Output	<i>Matching procurement plans and approved budget appropriations: Submission of procurement plans with budget by at least 70% of ministries, directorates and agencies</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>SOE operations are monitored, related fiscal risks identified and disclosed, and steps taken to improve their financial performance:</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Establishment of a PFM strategy action plan</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Establishment of a functioning PFM Coordinating Committee: Quarterly meetings held (2018)</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Annual comprehensive PFM progress report produced</i>	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	<i>Donor-supported PFM matrix endorsement</i>	No	Yes	Yes
	Outcomes			
CSP-Outcome	Government revenue transferred to local communities (%)	5	10	1
CSP-Outcome	Net domestic borrowing (% of GDP)	1	2	0.6
CB-Outcome	Interest payment (% of GDP)	7.7	4.90	3
CB-Outcome	Overall budget balance (% of GDP)	7.3	2.5	3.8
CB-Outcome	CPIA indicator 15: Strengthening human resources:	3.5	3.67	4.0
CB-Outcome	CPIA indicator 2: Quality of Budgetary and Financial Management.	3.4	3.62	3.0

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR, IIAG 2025, AEO 2024, PEFA 2024, CPIA 2024 & 2020 CPPR and 2017–2020 Country Brief Completion Report

B. Agriculture Output and Outcome Indicators 2017–2024

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Outputs			
CSP-Output	Area of additional irrigation schemes built or rehabilitated (Ha)	212	287	240
CSP-Output	Smallholder farmers benefiting from improved agriculture technologies—of which women (50%)	48	443 (222 women)	300 (no data)
	Outcomes			
	Post-harvest losses on agricultural value chain (%)			
CSP-Outcome	—Rice and dry cereals	10	7	11.9
CSP-Outcome	—Fruits and vegetables	50	30	40
	Boosting agricultural productivity (Tonnes/Ha):			
CSP-Outcome	—Rice	2.2	5	5
CSP-Outcome	—Cassava	6	10	6

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
CSP-Outcome	—Maize	2	4	3
CSP-Outcome	—Soybean	1.5	2.5	1.8
CSP-Outcome	—Sorghum	1.5	3	1.8

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP Completion Report & 2020 CPPR and 2017–2020 Country Brief Completion Report

C. Transport Output and Outcome Indicators 2017–2024

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Outputs			
CSP-Output	Port of Banjul expansion completed (Yes/No)	No	Yes	No
CSP-Output	Construction of One-Stop Border Posts with gender design feature	No	Yes	No
CSP-Output	Women accessing cross-border markets (%)	60	80	60
CSP-Output	Ancillary road (%)	0	100	100
CB-Output	Construction of One-Stop Border Posts with gender design feature	No	Yes	No
CB-Output	Institutional reforms	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	Construction of Trans-Gambia Bridge	No	Yes	Yes
CB-Output	Rural Access Index—improve access to transport in zone of influence within 2km of population homes: % accessible	0	100%	33%
	Outcomes			
CSP-outcome	Container throughput (% annual growth)	10	15	10
CSP-outcome	Reduced cargo stay in port (days)	8	4	8
CB-Outcome	<i>Reduced travel time across the Gambia River: Minutes of travel time</i>	79	30	15
CB-Outcome	<i>Reduced avg VOC by 25% (vehicle-km)</i>	0	0.25	0.25
CB-Outcome	<i>Reduced avg VOC by 90% (EUR/km)</i>	0	0.9	0.92
CB-Outcome	<i>Reduced waiting time at borders: Hours of waiting time</i>	4	2	4

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP completion Report & 2020 CPPR and 2017–2020 Country Brief Completion Report

D. Power Output and Outcome Indicators 2017–2024

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Outputs			
CSP-Output	Installation of 144 solar-powered water supply systems (#)	0	144	73
CSP-Output	Completion of a 225-kV western backbone interconnection line—OMVG project (Yes/No)	No	Yes	Yes
CSP-Output	Electricity access under GEAP project (# households and businesses)	18,000	61,000	10,000
CB-Output	Interconnection to the neighbor countries by end 2019	No	Yes	Yes
	Outcomes			
CSP-Outcome	Renewable energy generation in total energy supply (%)	2.1	5	5.25
CSP-Outcome	Transmission and distribution infrastructure capacity (MW)	100	114	144.6
CB-Outcome	<i>Electricity available in the country (MW)</i>	45	70	93.6
CB-Outcome	<i>Reduce average electricity tariff (USD/kWh)</i>	0.33	0.279	0.224

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP Completion Report & 2020 CPPR, and 2017–2020 Country Brief Completion Report

E. Health and Social Protection Output and Outcome Indicators 2017–2024 (CSP only)

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Outputs			
CSP-Output	Trained E-surveillance rolled out (of Staff)	35	500	600
CSP-Output	COVID-19 food support package operationalized (in GMD m)	0	200,000	200,000
	Outcomes			
CSP-Outcome	Early detection and reporting of epidemics (score out of 100)	36.9	40	40
CSP-Outcome	Health service delivery (# antenatal visits per pregnant woman)	3	4	4

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP Completion Report

F. Cross-cutting Issues: Output and Outcome Indicators (CSP only)

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Climate Change			
CSP-Output	Country global climate resilience and vulnerability index improved (ranking out of 192)	141	130	150
CSP-Output	Climate-proof projects (% of lending operations)	70	100	80
CSP-Output	Climate finance (% of lending operations)	29	40	40
	Gender			
CSP-Output	Farmers' production and value chains schemes supported with purposive services (50% youth, 52% women)	7,200	10,000 (1400 youth, 1456 women)	10,000 (no data on youth or women)
CSP-Output	SMEs supported for food production and nutrition	20	50 (of which 9 women)	50 (no data on women)
CSP-Output	Rural female smallholders using digital payment systems for access to agricultural inputs and services (%)	1	5	1
	Policy advice and knowledge			
CSP-Output	ESWs prepared (# of Gender Policy/Fragility Assessment/Post-COVID-19 Impact assessment)	0	3	3
CSP-Outcome	Improved financial markets and domestic resource mobilization (Yes/No)	No	Yes	Yes

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP Completion Report

G. Indicators excluded from overall assessment

Results indicators with results levels not identified

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Skills development and job creation			
CSP-No clear RF level	People trained on food safety & quality preparation and storage (#)	120	200	200
CSP-No clear RF level	Value chain actors targeted in project area (#)	12,450	20,000	15,750
	Fragility			
CSP-No clear RF level	Country Fragile States Index (0—low, 100—high)	83.9	80	76.1

Sources: 2024 Gambia CPPR and 2021–2025 CSP Completion Report

Results indicators without baselines and/or targets or not clearly defined

Results Level	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Most Recent Value
	Governance			
CB-Outcome	PEFA indicator PI-17 recording and management of cash balances, debt, and guarantees	B+	A	D+ (discontinued as an indicator during MTR due to methodological mismatch between 2011 and 2016 PEFA frameworks)
	Agriculture			
CB-Output	Area of additional irrigation schemes built or rehabilitated for all year-round sustainable agricultural production	0	No target	260ha ³⁷
CB-Output	Smallholder farmers benefiting from improved agriculture of which to women (50%)	0	No target	367,981 (no data on women)
CB-Output	Volume of additional water stored in irrigation infrastructure built to increase the irrigated area	0	No target	Not achieved
	Power			
CB-Output	Number of people with electricity connections (of which 50% women)	0	No target	1,300,000 (no data on women)
	Transport			
CB-Output	Number of women accessing cross-border markets	0	Not clearly defined	60% of women traders
	Increased access to sustainable WASH infrastructure and services in rural and peri-urban areas			
CB-Outcome	Increase in % of population with access to safely managed sanitation services incl. handwashing with soap & water (>50% women) (SDG6.2)	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0%
CB-Output	Solar-powered water supply systems constructed in rural and peri-urban areas	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	No
	Well-managed and better-performing rural WASH subsector			
CB-Outcome	% increase in rural WASH subsector investments	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0%
CB-Outcome	% increase in functionality of Rural WASH facilities	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0%
CB-Output	WASH baseline/KAP studies and Hygiene Promotion/Behavior Change campaigns (CLTS) undertaken	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Yes
CB-Output	Sanitation and hygiene facilities provided in rural and peri-urban areas	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	No

³⁷ From CB completion report.

	Improved incomes and well-being of the rural and peri-urban population			
CB-Outcome	Number of direct (temporary) jobs created (>30% women/40% youth)	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0
CB-Outcome	Number of direct (permanent) jobs created (>30% women/40% youth)	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0
CB-Outcome	Number of indirect and induced jobs created	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0
CB-Outcome	20% increase in number of employed youth active in WASH	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	0%
CB-Output	2.1 RWSD and other relevant sector institutions and systems strengthened	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
CB-Output	2.2 Oversight and coordination of water supply and sanitation services improved	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Achieved
CB-Output	2.3 Public and private sector staff trained	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Achieved
CB-Output	2.4 Capacity for efficient monitoring of water resources and WASH improved	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
CB-Output	2.5 MDFT/VDC/WASH committees established and trained	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Partially achieved
CB-Output	2.6 Knowledge and skills of school pupils and teachers in climate change and related green growth/economy enhanced	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
CB-Output	2.7 Sanitation Fund established	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
	Climate Change Mitigating Measures to protect aquatic environment implemented			
CB-Output	3.1 Ground water resource catchments protected	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Partially achieved
CB-Output	3.2 Climate Change Mitigating Measures to protect aquatic environment implemented □ SWM Improved	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
CB-Output	3.2 Climate Change Mitigating Measures to protect aquatic environment implemented □ Renewable energy source for fish processing and storage introduced	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved
CB-Output	3.3 Livelihoods of rural and peri-urban population improved	Not clearly defined	Not clearly defined	Not achieved

Sources: 2020 CPPR and 2017–2020 Country Brief Completion Report

Annex 3: Evaluation Scoring Criteria

Evaluation Criteria	Rating and Explanation
Relevance	4- Highly Satisfactory: The CSP interventions objectives in the sector are clearly <u>aligned to all</u> of the above evidence. The intervention design encompasses all the design attributes and solid criteria applied for selectivity. 3- Satisfactory: The CSP intervention objectives in the sector are clearly <u>aligned to most</u> of the above evidence. The intervention design encompasses most of the design attributes and selectivity mostly applied. 2- Partly Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions objectives in the sector are <u>aligned to few of</u> the above evidence. The intervention design encompasses few of the design attributes and there is little evidence of application of selectivity. 1- Unsatisfactory: The CSP intervention objectives are in the sector <u>not aligned to any</u> of the above evidence. The intervention design encompasses none of the design attributes and no intervention selectivity is applied
Coherence	4- Highly Satisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector have very good support, synergies and interlinkages, consistency (complementarity, harmonization, and coordination), with other interventions implemented by the same institution and those implemented by other partners in the same context. 3- Satisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector have mixed (achievements in most areas with few instances of limitations noted in some respects) support, synergies and interlinkages, consistency (complementarity, harmonization, and coordination), with other interventions implemented by the same institution and those implemented by other partners in the same context. 2- Partly Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector have poor (more limitations in all areas than achievements) support, synergies and interlinkages, consistency (complementarity, harmonization, and coordination), with other interventions implemented by the same institution and those implemented by other partners in the same context. 1- Unsatisfactory: The CSP intervention in the sector has very poor (non-existent achievement in all areas assessed) support, synergies and interlinkages, consistency (complementarity, harmonization, and coordination), with other interventions implemented by the same institution and those implemented by other partners.
Effectiveness	4- Highly Satisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector fully achieved the results under all the pillars of the strategy during the period (e.g., 100% of all the targets were met, and the discussion on qualitative indicators and/or any other relevant, verifiable evidence suggests the objectives are achieved). 3- Satisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector made good progress toward achieving the results under the pillars of the strategy during the period (e.g., 70–100% of the targets were achieved; discussion on qualitative indicators and/or any other relevant, verifiable evidence suggests the objectives are mostly achieved; and the evaluation provides a strong rationale for the missed targets). 2- Partly Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector made only limited progress toward achieving the results under the pillars of the strategy during the period (e.g., 40–70% of the targets were achieved; qualitative indicators and/or any other relevant, verifiable evidence have only seen limited progress). 1- Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions in the sector made little progress (less than 40%) toward achieving the results under the pillars of the strategy during the period (e.g., few if any of the targets were met; qualitative indicators have not been achieved).

Evaluation Criteria	Rating and Explanation
Efficiency	4. Highly Satisfactory: EIRR for all the CSP interventions in the sector are equal or above the opportunity cost of capital (OPC). Implementation of all the interventions were carried out on time (compared to the original PAR) and delivered all or more outputs and outcomes than expected within the available budget. 3. Satisfactory: EIRR for most of the CSP interventions in the sector under the pillars are greater or equal to 80% of the OPC but less than the OPC. Implementation of most of the interventions were done with less than 25% delay and delivered most of the outputs and outcomes within the available budget. 2. Partly Unsatisfactory: EIRR for the CSP interventions in the sector are greater than 40% of the OPC but less than 80% of the OPC. Implementation of the interventions was carried out with less than 50% (but with 25% or more) delay and delivered less outputs and outcomes within the available budget. 1. Unsatisfactory: Deficient quality in most aspects of the considered criterion; most of the dimensions of the criterion have not been met.
Sustainability	4- Highly Satisfactory: There is a very low likelihood that the achievement of the CSP results in the sector are adversely affected by factors related to the technical design of the interventions. The interventions have put in place robust mechanisms for economic and financial sustainability and were critical in building or strengthening institutional capacities in the concerned area. The interventions have been highly effective at involving all the relevant stakeholders and there is a strong sense of ownership among the beneficiaries and partners. The interventions fully meet all AfDB's environmental, social, health and safety (ESHS) standards and have resulted in significant environmental improvements 3-Satisfactory: There is relatively low likelihood that factors related to the technical design may adversely impact the achievement of the CSP results in the sector. The interventions have put in place sufficient mechanisms for economic and financial sustainability. Country systems and capacities are very good and deemed sufficient. The intervention has been effective at involving most stakeholders and promoting a sense of ownership among the beneficiaries. Most intervention components have in place robust mechanisms that are likely to ensure the continued flow of ESHS benefits. 2- Partly Unsatisfactory: There is a substantial likelihood that factors related to the technical design of the interventions may adversely impact the achievement of the CSP results in the sector. The interventions have put in place very few mechanisms for economic and financial sustainability. Country systems and capacities remain weak and are deemed insufficient to ensure the continued flow of benefits. The interventions have involved only a small number of stakeholders and there is limited ownership among the beneficiaries. The interventions only partially meet AfDB's ESHS standards, but corrective actions are under way. 1- Unsatisfactory: Deficient quality in most aspects of the considered criterion; most of the dimensions of the criterion have not been met.
Impact	4- Highly Satisfactory: The CSP interventions have demonstrably contributed (or are highly likely to contribute) to addressing higher-level developmental challenges. Benefits of the interventions have started to accrue to target group members, incl. the most vulnerable groups. All ESA recommendations have been adequately addressed, monitoring measures have been put fully in place, and any negative impact on environment or social groups have been avoided. 3- Satisfactory: The CSP interventions have demonstrated some contribution to addressing higher-level developmental challenges (or are likely to do so). Some benefits of the interventions have started to accrue to target group members, incl. the most vulnerable groups. Most ESA recommendations have been adequately

Evaluation Criteria	Rating and Explanation
	addressed, some monitoring measures have been put in place, and negative impact on environment or social groups have been largely avoided. 2- Partly Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions have contributed little to addressing higher-level developmental challenges (and are not very likely to contribute more). Few benefits of the interventions have started to accrue to target group members, but not necessarily the most vulnerable groups. Few ESA recommendations have been adequately addressed, few monitoring measures have been put in place, and there have been some negative impacts on environment or social groups. 1- Unsatisfactory: The CSP interventions have not contributed to addressing higher-level developmental challenges in any significant manner (and are unlikely to do so). No benefits of the interventions have accrued to target group members, nor to the most vulnerable groups. No or nearly no ESA recommendations have been adequately addressed, no monitoring measures have been put in place, and there has been significant negative impact on environment or social groups.

Annex 4: Documents Consulted

Year	Title
	African Development Bank
2012	The Gambia: Transport Sector Diagnostic Study
2017	The Gambia: Country Brief 2017–2019
2018	TransGambia Road Corridor Project: Environmental and Social Management Plan (ESMP) Summary.
2019	African Economic Outlook—Macroeconomic Performance and Prospects. Jobs, Growth and Firm Dynamism. Integration for Economic Prosperity
2019	2019 Country Resilience and Fragility Assessment Report
2020	African Economic Outlook—Developing Africa's Workforce for the Future
2020	The Gambia—Bank Group Country Brief 2017–2019 Completion Report and 2020 Country Portfolio Performance Review
2021	The Gambia—Bank Group Country Strategy Paper 2021–2025
2022	Strategy for Addressing Fragility and Building Resilience in Africa (2022–2026)
2022	Supporting Climate Resilience and a Just Energy Transition: Country Focus Report
2023	African Economic Outlook—Country Note
2023	Project Appraisal Report: Public Financial Management and Economic Reform Program (PFM-ERP)—Phase I
2024	African Economic Outlook: Country Focus Report — The Gambia
2024	The Gambia: Driving Transformation—Reform of the Global Financial Architecture. Country Focus Report
	Government of The Gambia
2020	Financial Inclusion. Central Bank of The Gambia
2018	National Nutrition Policy (2018–2025)
2023	Evaluation of AfDB's Support for the Transport Sector, 2012–2023
2018	National Transport Policy (2018–2027)
2018	Trade Policy (2018–2022)
2019	National Youth Policy (2019–2028)
2015	National Policy for Sanitation and Hygiene 2015–2020
2017	Agriculture and Natural Resources Policy (2017–2026)
2018	National Development Plan (2018–2022)
2019	National Agricultural Investment Plan (2019–2025)
2021	National Rice Development Strategy (2022–2030)
2021	Strategic Electricity Roadmap: Universal Access by 2025 and Transforming The Gambia Electricity Sub-sector
2022	Recovery-Focused National Development Plan (2023–2027)
1999	Vision 2020
2018	Youth and Trade Roadmap of The Gambia 2018–2022—Nuts and Agro-processing Sector
2016	Integrated Household Survey (IHS): 2016 & 2020 Statistical Abstract
2017	Integrated Household Survey 2015/2016
2018	National Development Plan, 2018–2021
2018	Labour Force Survey (GLFS 2018)
2025	The Gambia Aid Policy 2015–2020
	International Monetary Fund
2020	The Gambia—First Review of the Staff-Monitored Program
2024	Macroeconomic and Distributional Implications of Gender Gaps — The Gambia
2025	The Gambia: Second Review Under the Extended Credit Facility Arrangement
	World Bank
2017	Fragility Risk and Resilience Assessment. World Bank & African Development Bank
2025	World Development Indicators
2020	The Gambia—Joint Debt Sustainability Analysis. World Bank & IMF
2025	The Gambia—Joint Debt Sustainability Analysis. World Bank & IMF
	Others

Year	Title
2022	The Gambia: A Diagnostic Case Study. Climate Resilient Food Systems Alliance
2023	Fragile State Index Annual Report 2023. Fund for Peace
2025	Home-Grown School Meals Programme: Impact Evaluation. World Food Programme